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ONE SUSPECT DETAINED
Two Jaish terrorists gunned down in J&K
NEWS » PAGE 14

SEMICON INDIA 2026

PM pitches India as hub for chipmaking
NEWS » PAGE 14

NEET-SS CASE
Qualifying percentile will be cut to 30: govt.
NEWS » PAGE 16

PARLEY

Does BRICS meet signify a foreign policy shift?
Delhi declaration slams western sanctions, Israel
OPINION » PAGE 11

DOMINANT DISPLAY
Abhishek dazzles as India sweeps series
SPORT » PAGE 19

U.S. clears Russia sanctions Bill; India faces tariff threat

U.S. House clears legislation that will authorise the President to impose 100% tariffs on countries for buying oil and gas from Russia; committed to ensuring energy security for Indians, says New Delhi

Sriram Lakshman
WASHINGTON DC

The U.S. House of Representatives on Wednesday passed legislation targeting Russia's energy sector, individuals and the "shadow fleet" of tankers, including authorising the U.S. President to impose tariffs of up to 100% on India and other countries for buying oil and gas from Russia. The House voted 262-159 in favour of the Bill.

The Bill, an amendment to the Senate's "Lindsey O. Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act of 2026", will now head to President Donald Trump's desk for his signature. Mr. Trump plans to sign the Bill, a White House official told *The Hindu* on Thursday. The President will have the

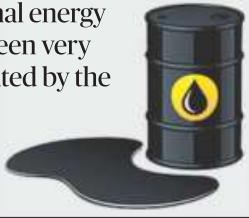
Who are the targets?

The Bill aims to dissuade countries from 'aiding Russian aggression' against Ukraine by purchasing Russian oil and gas

The Bill targets top five "largest importers, by total volume" in the 12 months preceding the date of enactment of the law, which have knowingly made new purchases on or after 30 days from the date the Bill becomes law

This issue has been discussed at high levels in recent months with various U.S. interlocutors. Its potential implications for not just the bilateral relationship but also the international energy market have been very clearly articulated by the Indian side

EXTERNAL AFFAIRS MINISTRY



Over half of oil imports in July were from Russia

NEW DELHI

Russia accounted for more than 51% of India's oil imports in July, an all-time-high, up from just a little less than 50% in the previous month, the latest official data show. An analysis of Commerce and Industry Ministry data shows India imported 110.4 lakh tonnes of Russian oil in July, the latest month for which data are available. » PAGE 17

Delhi and Washington have been negotiating a preliminary trade deal.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 14
CHINA, RUSSIA REACT
» PAGE 18

IN BRIEF



PAC criticises Railways over gaps in amenities

NEW DELHI

The Public Accounts Committee (PAC) on Thursday expressed concern over persistent deficiencies in passenger amenities and sanitation across railway stations in the country, at a meeting chaired by senior Congress leader K.C. Venugopal. » Page 16

CSAT Starts From 30th September
by AMIT GARG (Director- IAS SETU)
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Tata Sons Board backs N. Chandrasekaran; Trusts terms it illegal

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

A major dispute has arisen between Tata Sons Pvt. Ltd.'s Board and its majority owner, Tata Trusts, regarding the reappointment of N. Chandrasekaran as Tata Sons chairman and the listing of the company as mandated by Reserve Bank of India guidelines. Tata Trusts has termed the appointment "illegal".

On Thursday, at a scheduled board meeting of Tata Sons, the Board requested Mr. Chandrasekaran to reconsider his decision to not seek reappointment and continue for five years and he "acceded to the request".

"The Board thereafter resolved by a majority vote to re-appoint him as Executive Chairman for a further



N. Chandrasekaran

term of five years upon the expiry of his current tenure [in February 2027]," Tata Sons said in a statement.

On August 12, Mr. Chandrasekaran had said that he would not seek reappointment since one board member, Noel Tata, did not approve it.

NOEL TATA OPPOSES BID
» PAGE 14

EC bars rival factions from using TMC name, symbol for bypolls

Sreeparna Chakrabarty
NEW DELHI

The Election Commission (EC) in an interim order on Thursday barred both factions of the Trinamool Congress (TMC) from using the party symbol and name in the coming Assembly bypolls in Nandigram and Rejinagar in West Bengal.

The poll body asked both factions led by former West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee and Ritabrata Banerjee, who is currently the Leader of the Opposition in the Assembly, to submit alternative names and symbols for their groups for the byelections by 11 a.m. on Friday.

FULL REPORT ON
» PAGE 15

After claiming death benefits, 2,500 Odisha workers return for ration

Satyasundar Barik
BHUBANESWAR

In a bid to hoodwink Odisha's welfare machinery, almost 2,500 construction workers appear to have defied the rules of mortality – they died on paper, collected death benefits, and then came back to life to authenticate their Aadhaar and collect their monthly ration.

An audit has blown the lid off what appears to be a bizarre and massive fraud under the State's Nirman Shramik welfare scheme. As many as 2,487 construc-



ILLUSTRATION: SOUMYADIP SINHA

tion workers were declared dead and their nominees were paid death assistance, even though the workers continued to draw subsidised food

grains under the National Food Security Act (NFSA) and State Food Security Scheme after their recorded deaths.

The contradiction be-

comes even more startling in 753 cases. The audit found that these beneficiaries authenticated their Aadhaar biometrically to obtain ration after they had officially been declared dead. Death assistance amounting to ₹15.10 crore was subsequently paid to their nominees.

In other words, the government's records had buried the workers, while its ration system was still recognising their fingerprints.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 14

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INBRIEF



Jarange calls off fast, gives 3-month ‘ultimatum’ to govt.

Maratha quota activist Manoj Jarange-Patil ended his 20-day hunger strike on Thursday after discussions with a government delegation and giving the State a three-month ultimatum to meet his demands. “We won’t stop without getting what we want. We will give the government more time and have been fighting for three years, and we will show trust for three more months,” said Mr. Jarange-Patil after speaking to the delegation, including Minister Radhakrishna Vikhe Patil, Minister Dadaji Bhuse and MLAs Prasad Lad and Suresh Dhas.

CJP launches ‘Adivasi School Theek Karo’ in Rajasthan

The Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) on Thursday announced the launch of its “Adivasi School Theek Karo” campaign in Rajasthan and will visit government schools in tribal-dominated areas to document shortcomings in infrastructure and other facilities. During the campaign, its team will cover tribal areas in Udaipur, Dungarpur, Jhalawar, Banswara, Sirohi and Baran-Anta, among other places, the CJP said in a statement. It said its teams would document the condition of schools, identify shortcomings and take up the issues with the authorities concerned. The CJP said it would also monitor the implementation of announcements by the Rajasthan government for improvement of school infrastructure. PTI

Sanjay Jha facilitating JD(U)’s merger with BJP; can expect outcome soon, says Tejashwi

Amarnath Tewary
PATNA

Amid the controversy over implementing the Uniform Civil Code (UCC) in Bihar and the possibility of re-naming the ruling Janata Dal (United) to Janata Dal-Nitish, Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) leader Tejashwi Yadav on Thursday reiterated that JD(U) will now “merge” with the BJP, and that JD(U)’s national working president has been facilitating this “merger”. “JD(U)’s inability to come out with a clear stand on the UCC is proof of what holds for the party in the coming days. I’ve been saying again and again that JD (U) is a B-team of BJP and now I’m saying that the party will merge with the BJP in the coming days,” said the Leader of the Opposition while speaking to mediapersons in Patna.



RJD leader Tejashwi Yadav said JD(U)’s inability to come out with a clear stand on UCC is proof of what holds for the party. FILE PHOTO

“Earlier, we had said that Nitish Kumar will not be allowed to remain as the Chief Minister of the State and see what happened,” he pointed out. Meanwhile, JD(U) has called a meeting of all party leaders in Patna on Friday after Union Home Minister Amit Shah said that “UCC will be implemented in all 21-NDA ruled States by 2029”. Though political experts said the party would discuss these issues in the

meeting, JD(U) leaders said it would be the party’s “orientation and training programmes for lawmakers”. Experts from outside the State have been invited, said the party’s national working president, Sanjay Kumar Jha. Earlier, JD(U) leaders Shrawan Kumar and Deputy CM Vijay Kumar Chaudhary had said that the party would study the provisions of the UCC first and Mr. Jha “would hold talks with Mr. Shah over this”.

Arunachal CM denies govt. arm-twisting people to push mega dam on Siang river

Rahul Karmakar
GUWAHATI

Arunachal Pradesh Chief Minister Pema Khandu has trashed perceptions that the government was arm-twisting people to push a mega dam project on the Siang river, which flows as the Yarlung Tsangpo in Tibet upstream. The government remained open to discussions with villagers and organisations opposed to the proposed Siang Upper Multipurpose Project, Mr. Khandu said. The project’s capacity is expected to range between 11,000 megawatts (MW) and 12,500 MW. The Chief Minister’s assertion that “there is nothing forceful” came days af-



Pema Khandu said that the government’s doors are open for people who harboured concerns about the project. X/@PEMAKHANDUBJP

ter the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) registered a case against lawyer and anti-dam activist Bhanu Tatak for allegedly receiving foreign funds in violation of the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Act or FCRA. “The discussions on the proposed project and its pre-feasibility report have

been ongoing for two years. Many villagers have come forward and signed Memoranda of Understanding in favour of the project,” Mr. Khandu said. ‘Open for discussion’ The government’s doors were open for people who harboured concerns about the Siang Upper Multipur-

pose Project. “Any organisation, individual, or group with any doubt regarding the pre-feasibility report can come and discuss with the government,” he said. India has justified pursuing the project as a countermeasure against the 60,000 MW Medog hydropower station that China is building on the Yarlung Tsangpo. Although the Arunachal Pradesh government has garnered support from several villages for the Siang Upper Multipurpose Project, many people across four districts – East Siang, Siang, Upper Siang, and West Siang – are opposing the project over possible displacement, environmental impact, and seismic risks.

Gurugram hit-and-run accused chased woman biker for 2 km after party: SIT

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI

The main accused in the Gurugram hit-and-run case, Kalyan Bainsla, was returning from a party with his three friends when he chased a woman biker for 2 km on Golf Course Road before hitting her motorcycle, Special Investigation Team (SIT) sources said on Thursday. According to the SIT, Mr. Kalyan, who was driving the car, and his three friends had been at Empire Club Bar and Lounge in Sector 25 on the intervening night of September 13 and 14. His friend Mr. Lavnish, was seated in the passenger seat at the time of the incident, sources said. The first interaction bet-



Kalyan Bainsla (left) and Lavnish were nabbed from Rajasthan on September 15. PTI/ANI

ween the occupants of the car and the biker Shivani Chauhan, took place near Sector 53 Metro station, they said. Following a brief altercation, Mr. Lavnish instigated Mr. Kalyan to chase the biker, following which they pursued her for around 2 km before hitting her two-wheeler. The colli-



sion threw her off the motorcycle and she suffered injuries to her knees. Nabbd from Rajasthan Mr. Kalyan and Mr. Lavnish were nabbed from Rajasthan on September 15 and a case was registered under relevant sections. The sequence of events

remains the central focus of the investigation. While Ms. Chauhan has alleged that the occupants of the car were intoxicated and deliberately chased and hit her, Mr. Kalyan has said that the collision was an accident. The five-member SIT team investigating the case has also served notices to two other occupants of the car and their statements will be recorded to determine if their arrests are required. Additionally, investigators have sought the club’s CCTV footage; blood and urine samples of the accused have been sent for forensic examination. Meanwhile, Ms. Chauhan demanded action against everyone involved.

Rahul targets M.P. govt. over children’s deaths, calls it ‘most corrupt’

Mehul Malpani
BHOPAL

Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha targeted Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Mohan Yadav on Thursday while calling the BJP government in the State the “most corrupt and most incompetent” regime in the country.

Raising the issue of tribal children’s deaths in Balaghat district, Mr. Gandhi took a dig at the Madhya Pradesh government organising an event to light more than 25 lakh earthen lamps on the banks of Shipra river in Ujjain to mark Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s birthday.

“In Balaghat, more than 30 tribal children have died amid illness, malnutrition, and a lack of basic health facilities. The extent of the callousness is such that innocent children kept dying, yet the response remained sluggish, and the government stayed asleep. Mr. Chief Minister, if you’ve found time after lighting lamps and celebrating fes-



Rahul Gandhi flagged the demise of over 30 tribal children in Balaghat district. FILE PHOTO

tivals, take a look at the ground reality in the State,” he posted on X.

The Congress leader alleged that the children were dying because of “lack of disease control, nutrition, clean water, and a crumbling health system” in the State.

“Adulterated medicines and poisonous illegal liquor are devastating hundreds of families,” he said. “The Madhya Pradesh government is today India’s most corrupt and most incompetent government—that is the truth,” he charged.

KTR dares CM to order assets probe by judge into both their families

Day after Revanth alleged KCR had amassed land after coming to power, KTR says BRS is ready to face consequences if any wrongdoing proven

R. Ravikanth Reddy
HYDERABAD

Barat Rashtra Samithi (BRS) working president K.T. Rama Rao (KTR) on Thursday challenged Chief Minister A. Revanth Reddy to order an inquiry by a sitting High Court or Supreme Court judge into the assets of both the Chief Minister and the Leader of the Opposition (LoP) in the State.

His challenge came a day after the Chief Minister had alleged that KTR’s father K. Chandrasekhar Rao (KCR) – the LoP, BRS president and former Chief Minister – and his family members amassed huge lands in the name of agitation for a separate Telangana State as well as after coming to power in 2014.

Addressing a press conference, after hoisting the



BRS working president K.T. Rama Rao and party leaders unfurling the national flag in Hyderabad on Thursday. NAGARA GOPAL

national flag on Telangana National Integration Day, KTR said the inquiry should cover every acre of land and every rupee of assets acquired by the two families. He said the BRS was prepared to face any legal consequences if any wrongdoing was established against its leaders.

Referring to allegations over LoP and BRS president K. Chandrashekhara Rao’s (KCR) farmhouse at

Erravelli in Markook mandal of Siddipet district, he said the Chief Minister had earlier alleged that it was a 1,000-acre farmhouse but subsequently stated in the Assembly that the extent was 67 acres.

He asked Mr. Reddy to identify the remaining 933 acres and said the BRS would be prepared to register them in favour of the government if the allegation was established.

DUSU poll: HC threatens to stay counting over violence; teachers allege assaults

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Delhi High Court on Thursday cautioned that it could stay the counting of votes and declaration of results of the Delhi University Students’ Union (DUSU) elections if it was not satisfied with the action taken by the authorities over alleged violence and hooliganism during the campaign.

The warning came after the court was informed of alleged violence, vandalism, entry of outsiders and other violations during campaigning, which ended on Wednesday. Voting is scheduled for Friday and counting for September 19.

A Bench comprising Chief Justice D.K. Upadhyaya and Justice Tejas Karia directed Delhi Police and Delhi University to submit status reports by Friday and asked lawyers representing various student organisations to appear before it.

“No excuses will be ac-



Supporters of opposing student outfits clashing during campaigning in New Delhi on Wednesday. PTI

cepted by the court. We are making it very clear that though we are not staying the election or postponing the election, if we are not satisfied by your action, tomorrow we can pass harsher orders, including staying the counting and declaration of results,” the Bench said.

The court said criminal conduct could not be justified in the name of democracy and called the material before it indicative of a “complete failure” by the

authorities and students.

Campus violence

A group of Delhi University teachers has written to Vice-Chancellor P.C. Joshi seeking urgent intervention against alleged assaults, threats and misconduct towards teachers, following an incident at Motilal Nehru College (Evening) in which a teacher was allegedly assaulted by a group of students during the DUSU election campaign.

According to the teachers, the group of students attempting to enter the college for campaigning allegedly assaulted a teacher who tried to stop them. The students have not been identified, and their organisation is unclear.

The teachers called the incident “a matter of serious concern” and said similar instances of threats, intimidation and physical altercations involving teachers and students had been reported across the university.

SC notice on petition challenging woman’s ‘illegal’ deportation to Bangladesh

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Thursday issued notice to the Centre and Maharashtra authorities on a petition challenging the alleged detention and deportation of a woman to Bangladesh and the legality of the Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) dated

May 2, 2025, titled ‘Procedure for Deportation of Illegal Bangladeshi Nationals/Rohingya, regarding’, and the Immigration and Foreigners Order, 2025.

The petition was filed by Sahin Fakir, who alleged that his mother, Sahida, was illegally detained and “pushed out” of India into Bangladesh in July without any verification of her na-

tionality. He claimed that she was an Indian citizen and a permanent resident of Gobindapur in West Bengal’s North 24 Parganas district.

Appearing before a Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, senior advocate S. Muralidhar and advocate Prasanna S. challenged the provisions to the extent that

they permitted the removal of persons apprehended in India without safeguards prescribed by law and the Constitution.

The petition said the family’s connection with Gobindapur was corroborated by a representation signed by 63 permanent residents of the village, including Mr. Fakir and members of Ms. Sahida’s

family, seeking her immediate return to India.

SIR link

The petitioner linked his mother’s deportation to the recent special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in West Bengal.

He said her name had been deleted from the electoral roll during the SIR exercise despite her In-

dian identity and longstanding connection with the State being supported by identity and civil documents and historical electoral records. The deletion is under challenge before the competent tribunal, he said.

According to the petition, Ms. Sahida had travelled to Mumbai about 20 years ago with her hus-

band in search of livelihood and worked there as a domestic worker.

Deportation details

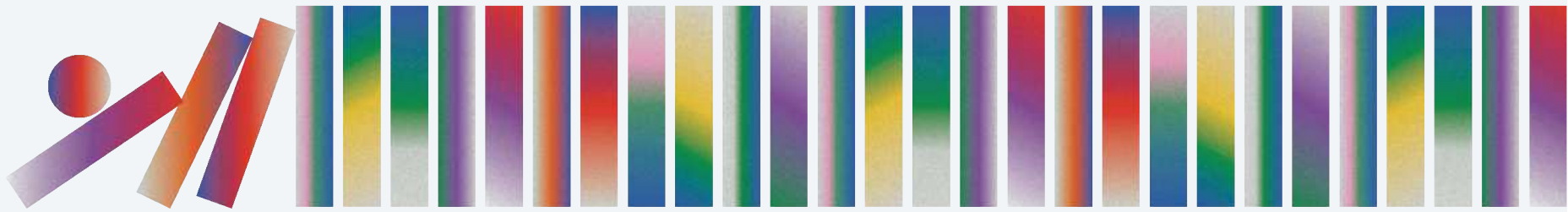
It alleged that she was intercepted in Mumbai on July 19 by persons identifying themselves as police personnel, forcibly apprehended and taken to a detention facility. Her identity documents and

mobile phone were allegedly taken from her.

The petition alleged that no fair inquiry into her nationality was conducted and that she was not given an effective opportunity to establish her Indian citizenship. It said she remained in custody for over 100 hours without being produced before a judicial magistrate.



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Smt. Nirmala Sitharaman
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National integration must involve equal rights for citizens: V-P

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

National integration must go beyond the geographical unification of territories and translate into equal rights, dignity and opportunities for citizens, Vice-President C.P. Radhakrishnan said on Thursday.

Addressing the Hyderabad Liberation Day celebrations organised by the Union Ministry of Culture, in Hyderabad, Mr. Radhakrishnan, who was the chief guest, said September 17, 1948, marked the culmination of a decisive chapter in the history of independent India with the integration of the erstwhile Hyderabad State into the Indian Union.

“Political integration can bring territories together; constitutional democracy brings citizens together,” he said, stressing that national unity could not be sustained by geography alone and had to be reinforced through equal rights, equal dignity and equal opportunity.

Recalling the contribution of Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel towards the integration of the princely States, Mr. Radhakrishnan said the first Home Minister had shouldered an extraordinary responsibility when the country was recovering from Partition and simultaneously consolidating hundreds of princely States into one Union.

Governor Shiv Pratap Shukla called upon people to draw inspiration from the sacrifices of the libera-



C.P. Radhakrishnan

tion heroes and contribute to building a strong, prosperous and developed Telangana.

‘People-centric govt.’ Meanwhile, Chief Minister A. Revanth Reddy appealed to the people to cooperate in building a modern Telangana, with the spirit of past struggles. He was speaking after unfurling the Tricolour at the Public Gardens here to celebrate the “Praja Palana Dinotsavam”.

“We are running a people-centric administration upholding the Telangana spirit and prioritising self respect of the people. Telangana is competing not just with neighbouring States but with the entire world,” he said.

Outlining the various initiatives launched by the Congress government since it took over the reins in December 2023, he said the State’s per capita income was ₹4.18 lakh, 91% higher than the national average. The government’s main goal, however, was to ensure that development was reflected not in statistics but in the actual lives of the people.

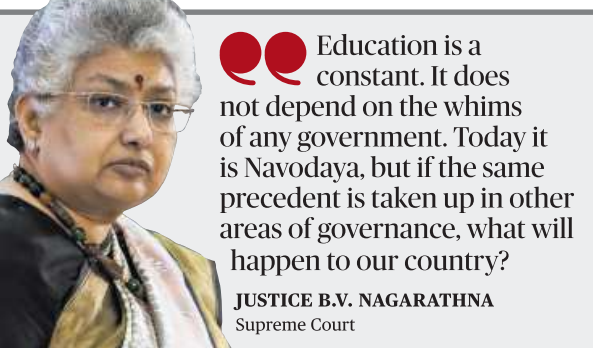
Navodaya case: SC tells T.N. to change ‘anti-Hindi’ mindset

Court says ‘individual States cannot act like individual countries’, gives govt. 3 months to identify land for Navodaya schools in each district; TVK govt. says choice of language is fundamental right

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Thursday said Tamil Nadu has to change the “mindset” that Hindi cannot be taught on the soil of the State, cautioning that “individual States cannot act like individual countries”. The oral observations from Justice B.V. Nagarathna came in a hearing on the adoption of the Navodaya Vidyalaya Scheme in Tamil Nadu.

The top court gave the State three months to comply with a December 15, 2025, order to identify the requisite land for Navodaya schools in each district. It said the direction would be subject to final orders passed later on. In the interregnum, the State and Central representatives were asked to discuss the policy of establishing Navodaya schools in Tamil Nadu. “Chennai should not



Education is a constant. It does not depend on the whims of any government. Today it is Navodaya, but if the same precedent is taken up in other areas of governance, what will happen to our country?

JUSTICE B.V. NAGARATHNA
Supreme Court

alienate Delhi, and vice versa, too,” Justice Nagarathna, heading a Bench including Justice A.G. Masih, addressed both governments.

The Tamil Nadu government has opposed the scheme as “fundamentally incompatible” with the State’s two-language policy. The previous Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) government, in an affidavit filed in March this year, had said the Navodaya scheme, based on the three-language formula,

deviated from the mandate of the Tamil Nadu Tamil Learning Act, 2006. The affidavit had alleged that the scheme was only a “backdoor” ploy to make Hindi compulsory.

On Thursday, the ruling Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) dispensation equally objected to the scheme, saying the choice of language is a fundamental right.

Senior advocate Jaideep Gupta and Tamil Nadu Additional Advocate-General Haripriya Padmanabhan,

for the State, said the scheme cannot be forced upon the State against its own policies and laws.

Mr. Gupta said ‘education’ was a subject in the Concurrent List.

“Navodaya is an optional policy... If the Supreme Court now issues a mandamus to the State to adopt that optional policy of the Centre, then My Lords, what you are doing is upsetting 75 years of decision-making by this court,” Mr. Gupta submitted.

“Change of government changes nothing. Education is a constant. It does not depend on the whims of any government. Today it is Navodaya, but if the same precedent is taken up in other areas of governance, what will happen to our country? You cannot say ‘I will not allow the national industrial policy or the national financial policy,’” Justice Nagarathna said.



Zubeen Garg died while swimming off an island near Singapore on September 19, 2025, triggering widespread outrage in Assam. FILE PHOTO

Assam govt. begins observing Garg’s first death anniversary with cultural events

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

Assam on Thursday began commemorating cultural icon Zubeen Garg’s first death anniversary with a series of cultural and spiritual programmes at Zubeen Kshetra, his memorial in Sonapur. The site on National Highway-27 is about 23 km east of Guwahati.

Garg died while swimming off an island near Singapore on September 19, 2025, triggering widespread outrage in Assam. Seven people were arrested in connection with his death.

‘Zubeen Divas’

“We have begun observing his death anniversary by marking September 17 as Zubeen Divas (Day),” the singer-composer’s wife Garima Saikia Garg said.

Cultural Affairs Minister Bimal Bora said the State government would handle

the logistics and provide other necessary support for the programmes, which include cultural functions and prayer sessions.

Thousands of Garg’s fans are expected to visit Zubeen Kshetra over the three days.

As a tribute to the cultural icon, the State Drivers’ Union has offered his fans low-fare rides to and from the venue during these three days.

Although the Singapore Police Force and State Coroner Adam Nakhoda ruled that Garg’s death was a case of accidental drowning with no evidence of foul play or murder, the Assam government formed a special investigation team (SIT) of the State police to fix responsibilities.

Of the seven against whom the SIT filed a chargesheet, four are facing murder charges. A special fast-track court in Guwahati is hearing the case.

INBRIEF



Shivakumar unveils Kalyana Karnataka Economy Mission

Karnataka Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar on Thursday announced the establishment of the Kalyana Karnataka Economy Mission (KKEM) as a Section 8 company (a non-profit organisation registered under the Companies Act) to attract investment and accelerate industrial development in the Kalyana Karnataka region. The Liberation Day is observed on September 17 every year to commemorate the end of the Nizam’s rule, and the region’s integration with the Indian Union in 1948.

Man attacks wife with ‘acidic substance’ in Bengaluru

A 26-year-old woman was attacked with a machete, and a suspected acidic substance was poured on her allegedly by her husband near a private hospital in J.P. Nagar in south Bengaluru on Thursday. The incident occurred when the woman, Madhumita, stepped out of the hospital where she was working. The accused, identified as Venkatesan, allegedly attacked her and fled for some distance before a traffic police intercepted and detained him. The couple, married three years ago, had been living separately for the past year following marital discord, the police said.

A.P. farmer, daughter found dead; 10-year-old son critical

A 44-year-old tenant farmer and his 13-year-old daughter were found dead in Gandrai village of NTR district of Andhra Pradesh on Thursday, the police said. His 10-year-old son, who was found in a critical condition along with them, is undergoing treatment in Hyderabad. The farmer, P. Srinivas, is suspected of having resorted to the extreme step after harming the children, the police said. What drove him to take the extreme step is yet to be ascertained, the police added. (For those in distress, counselling is available at Tele MANAS 14416.)

Ready for service



Rescue brigade: New recruits trained in firefighting, rescue operations, and disaster response pass out from the Kerala Fire and Rescue Services Academy in Thrissur, Kerala. K.K.NAJEEB

Keralam court sends Reporter TV director to judicial custody

The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI

Anto Augustine, managing director of Malayalam news channel Reporter TV, was remanded in judicial custody for 14 days by a Magistrate Court in Wayanad, Keralam, late on Thursday. He was earlier arrested by the excise officials on charges of alleged possession of liquor in excess of the legally permissible limit.

Mr. Augustine was taken into custody around 5 a.m. from the channel’s office at Kalamassery in Ernakulam district. The move followed the recovery of 67 litres of liquor from his an-

He was arrested by excise officials for allegedly possessing liquor in excess of the legal limit

cestral residence in Wayanad, on Wednesday by the special investigation team (SIT). The SIT is probing the alleged financial fraud linked to the failed bid to bring the Argentine national football team and its former captain Lionel Messi to Kochi for an international friendly last year.

The accused has been booked under Sections 55(a), 55(i), and 58 of the Kerala Abkari Act.

Karnataka’s financial aid scheme helped woman to sustain psychiatric care: study

The Hindu Bureau
MYSURU

A case study highlighting how financial assistance provided under the Karnataka government’s Gruha Lakshmi scheme helped a 40-year-old woman continue treatment for a chronic psychiatric disorder has been published in the *Digital Journal of Clinical Medicine*, brought out by the Elsevier publication for JSS Academy of Higher Education and Research (JSSAHER).

The case study concerns Girija (name changed), who was diagnosed with bipolar disorder and has been undergoing treatment for the past 25 years. A homemaker who has



The Gruha Lakshmi scheme provides ₹2,000 a month to eligible women identified as the heads of households. REPRESENTATIVE IMAGE

been married for 22 years, she belongs to a nuclear family from a lower socioeconomic background. Her husband works as a daily wage labourer.

Her psychiatric condition worsened amid financial stress in the house-

CMRL director also retracted statement to ED in pay-off case

The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI

S.N. Sasidharan Kartha, managing director of Cochin Minerals and Rutile Limited (CMRL), had also submitted a retraction affidavit to the Enforcement Directorate (ED) in 2024 in connection with the statements recorded in the Exalogic-CMRL pay-off case, it has now emerged.

CMRL’s former chief financial officer P. Suresh Kumar, along with the present chief general manager, had similarly submitted retraction affidavits to the ED in 2024.

Mr. Kartha was interrogated by the ED at his residence on April 17, 2024.

In his statement recorded under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act, Mr. Kartha allegedly admitted to transferring funds to vendors and withdrawing cash without genuine expenses. He also admitted to payments made to T. Veena, and her now-defunct firm Exalogic Solutions Pvt. Ltd.

In an email to the CMRL dated May 15, 2024, Mr. Kartha’s brother N. Ajith alleged that ED officials had forcibly recorded his brother’s statements. “I would like to inform you that in this connection, I had submitted a retraction affidavit, on behalf of my brother, to the Director, ED Delhi office,” the mail read.

OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

DEATH

PRAY FOR THE SOUL OF



ARUN MIRANDA
12TH JANUARY 1968 - 16TH SEPTEMBER 2026

Founder, Chairman & Managing Director
Astrotech Steels Private Limited
Triune Technofab Private Limited

*A loving Son, Husband, Father, Father-in-law, Grandfather,
Faithful Friend, and pillar of strength.*

"Remember that when you leave this earth, you can take with you nothing that you have received, only what you have given: a full heart enriched by honest service, love, sacrifice and courage."
-St. Francis of Assisi

Deeply mourned by family and friends, and the staff of
Astrotech Steels Pvt Ltd & Triune Technofab Pvt Ltd.

Funeral Mass at Annai Vailankanni Shrine,
Besant Nagar - Friday, 18th September, 9:30 am.

Astrotech Steels **TRIUNE TECHNOFAB**

SOUTHERN POWER DISTRIBUTION COMPANY OF TELANGANA LTD.
(A Govt. of Telangana Undertaking)
(Formerly Central Power Distribution Company of Andhra Pradesh Ltd.)
Corporate Office, 6-150 Mimi Compound - Hyderabad-43 (Telangana State, India)
CIN: U40109TG2005SGC034116

e-Procurement Tender Notice (Paper Notification)
TGSPODCL intends to float tenders for Conversion of existing Overhead line to Under-ground cable in various Circles of GHMC Metro Zone area of TGSPODCL on e-procurement platform. For further details of above, please visit <https://tgsouthernpower.org> and www.tendertelangana.gov.in. Phone: 040-23431321

DIPR R.O.No.542-PP/CL-AGENCY/ADVT/2026-27 Dt:17-09-2026 Sd/-CHIEF ENGINEER (PROJECTS)

TO ADVERTISE
PLEASE CONTACT

Mr. N SELVA KUMAR

PH: 9820350726

selvakumar.n@thehindu.co.in

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BANARAS LOCOMOTIVE WORKS, VARANASI - 221004

No. GSD/Scrap/Auction Programme/03/2026-27 Dated: 11.09.2026
AUCTION PROGRAMME NOTICE NO.GSD/BLW/SCRAP/03/2026-27
Following is the schedule of e-auction to be held in the month of **October, November & December** 2026 every Wednesday for sale of scrap under the jurisdictions of GSD/BLW, Varanasi.
Types of Auction: e-auction from (10:30 Hrs.), **Depot:** GSD/BLW/Varanasi, e-auction Date of **October-2026 (Wednesday):** 7th, 14th, 21st 28th e-auction Date of **November-2026 (Wednesday):** 4th, 11th, 18th 25th, e-auction Date of **December-2026 (Wednesday):** 02nd, 9th, 16th 23rd, 30th.
You are requested to actively participate in the above scheduled e-auction. For details please visit IREPS website at www.ireps.gov.in.
PRO/BLW/S-26 Dy. CMM/Depot
f t i @ /blwvaranasi Website: blw.indianrailways.gov.in

यू.पी. प्रोजेक्ट्स कारपोरेशन लि.
(उत्तर प्रदेश सरकार का उपक्रम) CIN : U15209UP1976SGC004285
कार्यालय महाप्रबंधक, जोन-5, बोया तट गोमती बेराज, गोमती नगर, लखनऊ-226010
सूत्रांप: 0522-3180555, ई-मेल: gmzone5@gmail.com, gm_5@upprojects.org

पत्र सं० : 326/पी.सी.एल./महाप्र/जोन-5/ई-निविदा दिनांक : 17.09.2026

अल्पकालीन ई-निविदा सूचना
जनपद झांसी के मुख्यमंत्री मॉडल कम्पोजिट विद्यालय-द्वितीय (फेज-2) ग्राम-मऊ देहात, तहसील-मऊनरानीपुर के निर्माण कार्य हेतु इस कार्यालय की ई-निविदा सूचना सं० 35/UPPCL/GM-5/E-TENDER/2026-27 दिनांक 17.09.2026 द्वारा ई-निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है। उक्त निविदा <http://etender.up.nic.in> की वेबसाइट पर दिनांक 28.09.2026 से दिनांक 05.10.2026 के अपराह्न 15:00 बजे तक डाउनलोड/अपलोड की जा सकती है। टेक्निकल बिड उसी दिन अपराह्न 16:00 बजे अधोहस्ताक्षरी के उपरोक्त कार्यालय में खोली जानी प्रस्तावित है। ई-निविदा से सम्बन्धित अन्य विवरण, नियम एवं शर्तें कारपोरेशन की वेबसाइट <https://uppprojects.upsdc.gov.in> पर देखी जा सकती है।
महाप्रबंधक जॉन-5

OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE
ENGINEER, GANGA JAL PROJECT UNIT
U.P. JAL NIGAM (URBAN)
PRATAP VIHAR, GHAZIABAD
E-mail: pmgangajalgzb@yahoo.com

Letter No.: 1515/Nivida/77
Dated: 17.09.2026

SHORT TERM E-TENDER NOTICE
On behalf of U.P. Jal Nigam (Urban) online e-tenders for execution of "Supply, fabrication & erection of 400 mm & 700 mm dia MS pipe including all other appurtenant work under 100 cusec Water supply scheme Ghaziabad". Bids are invited in two bid system on percentage rate basis from eligible, reputed and experienced bidders. E-tender documents will be available for download from **23.09.2026 at 17:00 Hrs.** E-bid can be submitted till **08.10.2026 up to 13:30 Hrs.** and technical bid shall be opened on **08.10.2026 at 15:30 Hrs.** in the office of The Executive Engineer, Gangajal Project Unit, U.P. Jal Nigam (Urban), Ghaziabad in presence of contractor or their authorized representative. E-tender Cost is **Rs. 3000.00+GST@18%**. Details are available on U.P. Govt. e-procurement portal <http://etender.up.nic.in> & U.P. Jal Nigam (Urban) website www.jn.upsdc.gov.in.

ଓଡ଼ିଶା ରାଜ୍ୟ ଯୋଗାଣ ନିଗମ लि.
ODISHA STATE CIVIL SUPPLIES CORPORATION LTD.,
(A Govt. of Odisha Undertaking)
REGISTERED OFFICE: C/2, NAYAPALLI, BHUBANESWAR-751012
CIN: U51211OR1980SGC000894
Tel No: 0674-3544751, Fax No: 0674-2395291, Website: www.oscsc.in

Notice inviting e-Auction of Custom Milled Rice(CMR)
RFP Advt. No.16228 / OSCSC Ltd., Date : 17.09.2026

Online Bids are invited exclusively from eligible exporters for the sale/disposal of Custom Milled Rice(CMR) through e-Auction conducted by NCDEX e Markets Limited(NeML) on behalf of Odisha State Civil Supplies Corporation Limited. All interested participants may visit www.oscsc.in & www.neml.in to view and download detailed terms and conditions of the RFP. The last date for registration with NeML and completion of formalities for the e-Auction is **06.10.2026 at 5.00 PM**. The date and time of the pre-bid meeting is on dated **30.09.2026 at 11.00 AM** at the Office of OSCSC Ltd, C/2 Nayapalli, Bhubaneswar. The changes/amendments (if any) in the RFP document shall be notified on the website mentioned above. The authority of OSCSC Ltd reserves the right to cancel any or the entire auction process without assigning any reason thereof. For more details, please refer to the detailed RFP published on the above websites.

Managing Director
Odisha State Civil Supplies Corporation Limited
7001/119/2627 OIPR-7001/7002/1/26-27/0010

HIMACHAL PRADESH PUBLIC WORKS DEPARTMENT
Telephone No. 01970233116, E-mail ID: ee-deh-hp@nic.in
INVITATION FOR BIDS (IFB)

The Executive Engineer Dehra Division HPPWD Dehra H.P. on behalf of Governor of H.P. invites the percentage rate bids, in the electronic tendering system from the eligible class of contractors registered with HPPWD for the works as detailed in the table.

SL No.	Name of work	Estimated Cost (Rs)	Starting Date for loading Bid	Earnest money (Rs.)	Deadline for submission of bid	Time Limit
1.	Construction of Parking Market and Office Complex Municipal Council at Dehra Tehsil Dehra Distt Kangra(H.P.) Deposit work(Sub Head:-C/O Building Portion including water supply & sanitary Installation and Rain water Harvesting System Etcetera.	R s. 4,71,79,850/-	24.09.2026	Rs. 9,44,000/-	30.09.2026	Eighteen Months
2.	Improvement of Single lane to intermediate lane lane Gopipur to Chamukha Road Km 6/00 to 900 (SH: C/O Formation cutting, 7/10 mtr wide, retaining wall extension of Hume pipe culvert, providing and laying metalling and tarring, U shape drain cement concrete pavement, crash barrier, road furniture.	Rs 2,79,52,253/-	24.09.2026	Rs. 5,59,000/-	30.09.2026	Nine Months

The bidders are advised to note other details of tender from the department website. www.hptenders.gov.in.
Date of opening of tender. 30.09.2026.

Executive Engineer,
Dehra Division HPPWD., Dehra
Pin No. 177101.
Tel. No. 01970-233116.
e-mail- ee-deh-hp@nic.in

HP / 3466/26-27 HIM LOK SAMPARK on behalf of Governor of Himachal Pradesh

SECTION 1
Superintending Engineer 14th Circle, HPPWD Rohru
(Name of Authority Inviting Bids)
NOTICE INVITING TENDER (NIT)

The Superintending Engineer, 14th Circle, HPPWD., Rohru on behalf of Government invites the percentage rate bids, in electronic tendering system, for construction of roads under Pradhan Mantri Gram Sadak Yojana for each of the following works including their maintenance for five years from the eligible and approved contractors registered with HPPWD/CPWD/P&T, Railways/other state govts /Central Govt agencies. Non-registered bidders may submit bids; however, the successful bidders must get registered in appropriate class with appropriate authorities before signing the contract.

Sr. No.	Name of Distt.	Package No.	Name of work under PMGSY-IV Batch-I	Estimated Cost (in lacs) Excluding GST	Const. Cost (in lacs)	Maint. Cost (in lacs)	Total Cost (in lacs)	Period of completion on (in lacs)	Bid Security (in lacs)	Tender Fee Non refundable (in Rs.)
1.	Shimla	HP-09-450	C/O Balance work of Tikhari to Keterwari/Dodra Kwar (portion from Larot to Chanshal Pass Km. 11/0 to 30/0 (SH:- C/O R/Wall, B/Wall, PCC parapets V-Shape drain MTX drainage work ordinary KM stone & 200mm stone etc) and five year maintenance Km. 11/0 to 30/0)	913.95	114.70	1028.65	06 months	20.57	20000	

- Date of release of invitation for bids through e-procurement **18.09.2026**
- Cost of bid from as above per job (Non-refundable)
- Availability of Bid Document and mode of submission: - The bid document is available online and bid should be submitted online on website <http://www.hppwdtenders.gov.in>. The bidder would be required to register in the website which is free of cost.
- Last date/Time for receipt of bid through e-tendering last date/time for receipt of bids through e-tendering on dated **02.10.2026 up to 6:00PM**
- The technical qualification part of the bids will be opened online at **11:00 A.M. on 03.10.2026**.
- Other details can be seen in the bidding documents. The officer inviting tender shall not be held liable for any delays due to system failure beyond its control. Even though the system will attempt to notify the bidders of any bid updates, the Employer shall not be liable for any information not received by the bidder. It is the bidders' responsibility to verify the website for the latest information related to the tender.

(Ravi Bhatti)
Superintending Engineer
14th circle HPPWD Rohru

HP / 3454/26-27 HIM SUCHANA AVAM JAN SAMPARK

NOTICE INVITING BID
Odisha State Medical Corporation Limited (OSMCL)
In front of Ram Mandir, Convent Square, Unit-III, Bhubaneswar-751001
Tel.:(0674) 2380950; Website: <https://osmcl.odisha.gov.in> ;
Email: drugs-osmcl@od.gov.in

Ref. No.: OSMCL/2026-27/DRUGS-DHS-GEN-GR-III/05 Date : 18/09/2026

Online Bids through e-Tender portal (<https://tendersodisha.gov.in>) are invited from eligible bidders for Supply of Drugs & Medical Consumables as per the particulars mentioned below :

Sl. No.	Particulars	Date and time
1.	Date & time of release of bid	18/09/2026, 3 PM
2.	Date & time for submission of queries by E-Mail id - drugs-osmcl@od.gov.in	22/09/2026, up to 5:00 PM
3.	Date & time of Online bid submission	Start Date & Time 28/09/2026, 3 PM End Date & Time 26/10/2026, 6.00 PM
4.	Date & time for submission of Tender Documents, Tender Document Fee and EMD amount as per section-IV of tender document.	Start Date & Time 27/10/2026, 10 AM End Date & Time 03/11/2026, 11.00 AM
5.	Date & time of Online Technical bid Opening	03/11/2026, 11:30 AM
6.	Date of opening of Price Bid	To be informed to the qualified bidders

The bid document with all information relating to the bidding process including cost of bid document, EMDs, Prequalification criteria and terms & conditions are available in the websites: <https://osmcl.odisha.gov.in> and <https://tendersodisha.gov.in>. The Authority reserves the right to accept / reject any part thereof or all the bids without assigning any reason thereof. All notice will be published in the OSMCL website <https://osmcl.odisha.gov.in>. Hence the bidders are requested to visit OSMCL website <https://osmcl.odisha.gov.in> time to time for any published notice against the tender.

SD/-
Managing Director, OSMCL Ltd., Odisha
10001/550/2627 OIPR-10001/10112/1/26-27/0010

UTTARAKHAND POWER CORPORATION LIMITED
(A Govt. of Uttarakhand Undertaking), Corporate Identity No. U40109UR2001SGC025867/2358,
Victoria Cross Vijeta Gagar Singh Urja Bhawan, Kanwali Road, Dehradun-248001,
Telephone - (0135) -276367/2-76, Fax-(0135) -2760289, Website: www.uktenders.gov.in

E-TENDER NOTICE (NIT)

Uttarakhand Power Corporation Ltd. Dehradun invites e- tender for following as detailed below:-

Sl. No.	Name of work	Tender Specification No.	Tender Qty.	Estimated cost (in ₹)	Average yearly Turn Over of Preceding Three Financial Year i.e. 2022-2023, 2023-2024 & 2024-2025 (in ₹)	Earnest Money (in ₹)	Cost of tender document including GST (in ₹)	Date & time of Prebid conference in online mode	Last Date & time of online request for Tender and submission of tender in online & Offline mode	Date of opening of bid Part-I in online and offline mode
1	LT XLPE AI. Cable 1x70Sq.mm.	CCP-I/28/2026-2027	25 Km	41,25,000.00	5,62,65,000.00	7,50,200.00	17,700.00	25.9.2026 at 12.00 Hrs.	7.10.2026 upto 17:00 hrs	8.10.2026 at 15:30 hrs
2	LT XLPE AI. Cable 1x120Sq.mm.		25 Km	59,00,000.00						
3	LT XLPE AI. Cable 1x240Sq.mm.		25 Km	95,00,000.00						
4	LT XLPE AI. Cable 1x630Sq.mm.		15 Km	1,79,85,000.00						

For further details, please visit the website www.uktenders.gov.in
No.: 733/EE/(CM)/UPCL/A-2 Dt. 16.09.2026

SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER CORPORATE (C&P-I)

"SAVE ELECTRICITY IN THE INTEREST OF THE NATION. Use LED Bulb, Save Electricity (Toll Free No. 1912) "Pay Electricity Bill Online 24x7 from www.upcl.org". (For information on Electricity theft, informer may report to Toll free No 1800 180 4185/ Fax No. 0135-2760911)

UTTAR PRADESH JAL NIGAM (URBAN), OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER, GANGA JAL PROJECT UNIT, U.P. JAL NIGAM (URBAN), PRATAP VIHAR, GHAZIABAD.
Letter No. 1518/Nivida/80
Dated: 17/09/2026
E-Tender Notice
U.P. Jal Nigam (Urban) online e-tenders for execution of "M.S fencing work and other painting work at Primary treatment work (Intek) dasna under 50 Cusec water supply scheme Ghaziabad." Bids are invited in two bid system on percentage rate basis from eligible reputed and experienced bidders. E-tender documents will be available for download from 23.09.2026 at 17:00 Hrs., Pre-Bid meeting will be held on dated 30.09.2026 at 13:30 hrs. in the office of under signed. E-bid can be submitted till 22.10.2026 up to 17:00 Hrs. and technical bid shall be opened on 23.10.2026 at 13:00 Hrs. in the office of The Executive Engineer, Gangajal Project Unit, U.P. Jal Nigam (Urban), Ghaziabad in presence of contractor or their authorized representative. E-tender Cost is Rs. 3000.00+GST @18%. Details are available on U.P. Govt. e-procurement portal <http://etender.up.nic.in> & U.P. Jal Nigam (Urban) website www.jn.upsdc.gov.in.

UTTAR PRADESH JAL NIGAM (URBAN), OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER, GANGA JAL PROJECT UNIT, U.P. JAL NIGAM (URBAN), PRATAP VIHAR, GHAZIABAD.
Letter No. 1517/Nivida/79
Dated: 17/09/2026
E-Tender Notice
U.P. Jal Nigam (Urban) online e-tenders for execution of "M.S fencing work and other painting work at Primary treatment work (Intek) dasna under 100 Cusec water supply scheme Ghaziabad." Bids are invited in two bid system on percentage rate basis from eligible reputed and experienced bidders. E-tender documents will be available for download from 23.09.2026 at 17:00 Hrs., Pre-Bid meeting will be held on dated 30.09.2026 at 14:30 hrs. in the office of under signed. E-bid can be submitted till 22.10.2026 up to 17:00 Hrs. and technical bid shall be opened on 23.10.2026 at 14:00 Hrs. in the office of The Executive Engineer, Gangajal Project Unit, U.P. Jal Nigam (Urban), Ghaziabad in presence of contractor or their authorized representative. E-tender Cost is Rs. 3000.00+GST @18%. Details are available on U.P. Govt. e-procurement portal <http://etender.up.nic.in> & U.P. Jal Nigam (Urban) website www.jn.upsdc.gov.in.

OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER, GANGA JAL PROJECT UNIT U.P. JAL NIGAM (URBAN) PRATAP VIHAR, GHAZIABAD
E-mail: pmgangajalgzb@yahoo.com

Letter No.: 1516/Nivida/78
Dated: 17.09.2026

SHORT TERM E-TENDER NOTICE
On behalf of U.P. Jal Nigam (Urban) online e-tenders for execution of "Supply and fixing of Air Valves, Sluice Valve and Construction of NHAI Drain Duct including other appurtenant work under 50 cusec and 100 cusec Water supply scheme Ghaziabad". Bids are invited in two bid system on percentage rate basis from eligible, reputed and experienced bidders. E-tender documents will be available for download from **23.09.2026 at 17:00 Hrs.** E-bid can be submitted till **08.10.2026 up to 13:00 Hrs.** and technical bid shall be opened on **08.10.2026 at 15:00 Hrs.** in the office of The Executive Engineer, Gangajal Project Unit, U.P. Jal Nigam (Urban), Ghaziabad in presence of contractor or their authorized representative. E-tender Cost is **Rs. 3000.00+GST@18%**. Details are available on U.P. Govt. e-procurement portal <http://etender.up.nic.in> & U.P. Jal Nigam (Urban) website www.jn.upsdc.gov.in.

OFFICE OF THE SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER, CONSTRUCTION CIRCLE, U. P. JAL NIGAM (URBAN), JHANSI
Letter No. : 1341/F-3/201
Dated: 17.09.2026
E-Tender Notice
Online percentage rate e-tender in Two Bid system under S.B.M.(U)-2.0 Programme are hereby invited on behalf of the Chairman, U.P. Jal Nigam (Urban) for Investigation and survey (on GIS basis) of the project area including soil investigation, Engineering Design (hydraulic and structural) as required, Procurement of all labour & material, T&P etc. and construction of various components complete for "Used Water Management (WSP) For Nagar Panchayat Badagan Distt. Jhansi", U.P., India on Turnkey Basis., from eligible, reputed and experienced bidder. E-bid documents will be available for download from 21.09.2026 by 17:00 Hrs. E- bids can be submitted till 08.10.2026 up to 15:00 Hrs. and technical bid shall be opened on 08.10.2026 at 15:30 Hrs. in Office of The Superintending Engineer, Construction Circle, U.P. Jal Nigam (Urban), Jhansi in presence of contractor or their authorized representative. E-tender Cost is Rs 10000.00 + GST @ 18% for tender. Details are available on U.P. Govt. e-procurement portal <http://etender.up.nic.in> & U.P. Jal Nigam (Urban) website www.jn.upsdc.gov.in.

GOVERNMENT OF JAMMU AND KASHMIR AGRICULTURE PRODUCTION DEPARTMENT MISSION DIRECTORATE, HADP / JKICP
Rajbagh, Srinagar / Narwal, Jammu
CORRIGENDUM
No.: MD/HADP/JKICP/Acctt/2026/26
Dated: 07.09.2026

The Notice Inviting e-Tender for the work detailed below, published on the J&K e-Procurement Portal, www.jktenders.gov.in, is hereby cancelled.

Notice Inviting e-Tender No.	MD/HADP/JKICP/Acctt/2026/18 dated 31.08.2026
RFP No.	RFP-12-JKICP-2026-27 / IND-2000003933-0403-W-NCB
Tender ID	2026_APD_322964_1
Name of Work	Supply, Installation, Testing and Commissioning of Water Management Systems for Horticultural Crops, Jammu Region
Date of publication	03-09-2026, 01:00 PM
Status	Cancelled. The work will be retendered.

The cancellation is made under ITB clause 36 of the bidding document, which allows the Employer to annul the bidding process and reject all bids at any time before award of contract, without any liability to any bidder. The work will be retendered and a fresh Notice Inviting e-Tender will be published on the portal shortly. Bidders who have already submitted their bids need not take any further action, and Bid Security, if any, will be returned. Bidders are advised to watch the portal for the fresh notice.

-sd-
Accounts Officer
Mission Directorate, HADP / JKICP

GOVERNMENT OF JAMMU AND KASHMIR AGRICULTURE PRODUCTION DEPARTMENT MISSION DIRECTORATE, HADP / JKICP
Rajbagh, Srinagar / Narwal, Jammu
NOTICE INVITING e-TENDER (RETENDER)
No.: MD/HADP/JKICP/Acctt/2026/27
Dated: 07.09.2026

The Employer, Mission Directorate, HADP/JKICP, invites electronic bids from eligible and registered firms for the following work, financed by the International Fund for Agricultural Development (IFAD), through national competitive bidding:

RFP No.	RFP-12-JKICP-2026-27 / IND-2000003933-0403-W-NCB
Name of Work	Supply Installation, Testing and Commissioning of Water Management Systems for Horticultural Crops, Jammu Region
Bid Security (EMD)	Rs. 13,00,000. No exemption is allowed.
Cost of Bidding Document	Nil
Bid submission starts	08-09-2026
Last date and time of bid submission	29-09-2026 at 10:30 hours IST
Opening of technical bids	29-09-2026 at 12:00 hours IST
Reference	This notice is issued in supersession of Notice Inviting e-Tender No. MD/HADP/JKICP/Acctt/2026/18 dated 31.08.2026 (Tender ID 2026_APD_322964_1), which stands cancelled.

The complete bidding document, eligibility criteria, terms and conditions and corrigenda, if any, are available on the J&K e-Procurement Portal www.jktenders.gov.in and may be downloaded free of cost. Bids shall be submitted online only. The Employer reserves the right to accept or reject any or all bids without assigning any reason.

-sd-
Accounts Officer
Mission Directorate, HADP / JKICP

GOVERNMENT OF JAMMU AND KASHMIR AGRICULTURE PRODUCTION DEPARTMENT MISSION DIRECTORATE, HADP / JKICP
Rajbagh, Srinagar / Narwal, Jammu
CORRIGENDUM
No.: MD/HADP/JKICP/Acctt/2026/42
Dated: 14.09.2026

On the J&K e-Procurement Portal, www.jktenders.gov.in, the tender detailed below displays the Bid Security (EMD) as 65211760. That figure is wrong and has been entered in error. It is only a portal entry and is not part of the bidding document. The correct Bid Security (EMD) for this tender is Rs. 13,00,000, as stated in the Notice Inviting e-Tender and in the bidding document.

Notice Inviting e-Tender No.	MD/HADP/JKICP/Acctt/2026/15 dated 31.08.2026
RFP No.	RFP-09-JKICP-2026-27 / IND-2000003933-0453-W-NCB
Tender ID	2026_APD_322902_1
Name of Work	Supply, Installation, Testing and Commissioning of 185 Standard Composite Solar Powered Fencing Systems, Kashmir Region
Date of publication	01-09-2026
Bid Security (EMD) shown on the portal	65211760 (incorrect)
Correct Bid Security (EMD)	Rs. 13,00,000 (Rupees Thirteen Lakh only)

Bidders shall furnish Bid Security (EMD) of Rs.13,00,000 only, in the form and manner stated in BDS ITB 20.1 and 20.2. No bidder is required to furnish any amount higher than Rs. 13,00,000, and no bid shall be treated as non-responsive for having furnished Rs.13,00,000. Bidders who have already obtained an instrument for the figure displayed on the portal may replace it with an instrument for Rs. 13,00,000 before the last date and time of bid submission. All other terms, conditions and dates of the tender remain unchanged. This corrigendum shall form part of the bidding document.

-sd-
Accounts Officer
Mission Directorate, HADP / JKICP

DIPK-NB-1662/26

SPOTLIGHT



Prime Minister Narendra Modi with BJP national president Nitin Nabin and the party's newly appointed national office-bearers during an organisational meeting at the BJP headquarters, in New Delhi on August 22. ANI

A piecemeal reset

Apart from the usual distribution of organisational berths to poll-going States, caste groups, and other demographics of sex and age, the new BJP team reflects the party's attempts at a reset. **Nistula Hebbar** reports on how three terms in power have brought both the pieties of the past and anxieties of the future into focus

Prime Minister Narendra Modi walked into a meeting of the newly appointed Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) national office-bearers on August 22. The 64 of office-bearers present assumed he would address them on how they should approach their assignments. Instead, he spent the next four-and-a-quarter hours individually querying them on their past organisational work.

The exchange was unhurried, with Modi at one point telling the audience that he too was once like them, a national office-bearer of the party during the late Atal Bihari Vajpayee's tenure as Prime Minister (1999-2004), say some of the new office-bearers.

The identification was interpreted in some quarters as a pep talk to the new team of how far organisational service can take you in the BJP, but for others it pointed to a unifying characteristic in a list of names that otherwise lacked a meta narrative, and instead, in a piecemeal fashion exhibited the political anxieties of the BJP.

This privileging of organisational experience by the Prime Minister was the highlight of the new team. The BJP, now in its third term in power and seeking a fourth in 2029, is, with this new team, attempting a reset amid various political anxieties.

Journalist Shekhar Iyer, who has tracked the BJP for decades, says, "The new team marks a big shift in the party top brass' approach to the challenges ahead of the 2029 Lok Sabha poll. Increasingly, the BJP is signalling to itself that, henceforth, the chosen men and women will represent less of their individual personality and more of their abilities and capabilities for the tasks to be accomplished."

This means the BJP is choosing workers over personalities, some of whom may not be known to the world outside the party. "If they meet the expectations of the top brass, they will move up the ladder faster," Iyer says.

The only exception to this weight given to backroom operators is former Union Minister and current general secretary Smriti Irani, whose oratorical skills have been considered valuable.

The only two general secretaries retained from the older team, Vinod Tawde and Sunil Bansal, have had a good run with Bihar and West Bengal respectively, States they were in charge of. Others such as general secretaries Satish Poonia and Biplab Deb, as well as new vice-president Ram Madhav also have a proven track record of behind-the-scenes organisational work in Jammu and Kashmir, West Bengal and Haryana.

The BJP's anxieties have more to do with the party's ability to run the election machinery.

2024 Lok Sabha poll and its discontents

The new list of office-bearers hides within it attempts to settle the disquiet engendered by the results of the Lok Sabha poll of 2024, which saw the BJP lose its single-party majority.

The unease between the BJP and its ideological mothership, the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), stood out during the 2024 election. It became public when the then BJP president, J.P. Nadda, said during an interview that the party did not require the help of the RSS as electoral muscle, adding that the BJP was "saksham" or



The BJP is signalling to itself that, henceforth, the chosen men and women will represent less of their individual personality and more of their abilities and capabilities for the tasks to be accomplished

SHEKHAR IYER
Journalist

adequate for the task.

Long-held resentments within the RSS – of the parent organisation being overlooked while its political wing, the BJP, flexed its muscles – burst to the fore, with particularly harmful effects for the party's prospects in Maharashtra, where the Mahayuti alliance of the BJP, the Eknath Shinde-led Shiv Sena and the Ajit Pawar-led Nationalist Congress Party suffered electoral losses.

In the Assembly election in the State later that year, this uneasiness was resolved by a coordination mechanism between the BJP and the RSS. The latter was headed by office-bearer Atul Limaye, who helped deliver a win to the alliance.

The awareness that the RSS and the BJP needed each other to remain in power had been reinforced by the results of the Lok Sabha election of 2024.

The return of Madhav, first as poll in charge of Jammu and Kashmir in the 2024 Assembly election, the first such poll after it became a Union Territory and after the reading down of Article 370 in 2019, and as vice-president in August 2026 was the second part of this rapprochement.

The understanding within the Sangh Parivar that internal issues should not endanger the government was driven home to the RSS and the BJP. Madhav, in an interview to *The Hindu*, described himself as someone who believed in a "middle path". In this case, he was the halfway meeting point for the BJP and RSS.

Insider, outsider

A few months before the BJP announced its new team of national office-bearers, a meeting was held at Defence Minister and former party president Rajnath Singh's residence.

Those present included not just the new BJP president Nitin Nabin, but also Union Home Minister Amit Shah, party's general secretary (organisation) B.L. Santhosh, and senior office-bearers of the RSS.

The topic of discussion was how to reconcile the aspirations of old-timers in the party with the flood of newcomers in the BJP since it came to power. This was not a new discussion. In an interview just before the Assembly poll in Assam this year, BJP vice-president and Assam in-charge Bajajant Panda, who was earlier with the Biju Janata Dal, told *The Hindu* that selectivity in distributing tickets to newcomers was the answer to the conundrum.

The BJP has profited from outside talent, especially since 2014. Three of the party's Chief Ministers – Himanta Biswa Sarma in Assam, Samrat Choudhary in Bihar and Suwendu Adhikari in West Bengal – have joined the BJP from other political parties.

In the new team, Rohan Gupta, who joined the BJP from the Congress, and Sandeep Pathak, who came from the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP), have been appointed as national secretaries. They don't qualify as long-term players within the party, but they do bring in the value of being backroom operators, with Pathak especially valued for his organisational work for AAP before the Punjab poll of 2022, which AAP had won.

The apprehensions of old-timers in the BJP, who see the party expanding with little reward for themselves, are being soothed by making newcomers do the organisational grind.

All the president's men

Another issue that arose during the Lok Sabha poll of 2024 was the perception that the organisation's work was subordinate to that of the government, that the strings of the party were being pulled by a high command, at the cost of the authority of the BJP president.

"Naddaji had been a general secretary in the national team in the past, served an apprenticeship under Amit Shah as the national working president of the BJP in 2019 and his subsequent team gave no inkling of his own personal likes or

dislikes," said a senior office-bearer in the BJP.

In Nabin's case, however, he has had remarkable autonomy in bringing people with whom he shares a good rapport into his team. BJP's national secretaries Swadesh Singh and Siddharth Shambhu are known to enjoy Nabin's trust, as does the newly appointed chief of the party's Scheduled Caste wing, Shivesh Ram. The new social media cell chief of the party, Deepak Mhaskey from Chhattisgarh, has also been hand-picked by Nabin, who had worked with him when Nabin handled the 2023 Assembly poll in that State.

Gen Z protests and social media

It was Mhaskey's appointment, replacing long-serving IT cell chief Amit Malviya, that made headlines after the new team was announced. The announcement came on the back of the Gen Z protests against the NEET paper leak, and the pasting that the BJP and the government took on social media throughout that period. That was a departure for a party that had, for the previous 12 years held a tight hold over the narrative, especially on social media.

One reason given for his replacement was the need for the BJP to strategise differently to counter this narrative. At a brainstorming session held soon after the new team's announcement, with many of its young leaders called in, it was decided not to look at Gen Z as a homogeneous unit. Ami Shah, a political communications professional and visiting faculty member at IIM Bangalore, says that the BJP had hyperlocalised communications in Maharashtra in 2014.

She speaks about having studied the jokes and humour, which were segmented, with people from Vidarbha preferring slapstick humour, while those in Konkan preferred wit.

"The BJP deployed its cultural knowledge of the area effectively in the Assembly poll in Maharashtra in 2014," she said.

Mhaskey is supposed to channel these segmented tier-two city and rural sensibilities in the BJP's communications game, but has had a rough start. Most of his team leaders, Priti Gandhi, Alok Bhatt and Arun Yadav, have had to delete objectionable posts from their social media handles, and some of the content put out by State BJP IT cells and even by the Centre trying to use Gen Z language has turned out to be tone-deaf.

When the new team was announced by the BJP, the party was careful to point out that six of the office-bearers were below the age of 40.

There are 15 between the ages of 40 and 49 and 21 between 50 and 59, bringing the average age of office-bearers to 50 years. More than 40% of the office-bearers come from marginalised communities. Moreover, 12 women from across the country have also made the cut.

The current national team faces the unprecedented challenge of steering the BJP's efforts to win a fourth term in office in 2029. Apart from the usual distribution of organisational berths to poll-going States, caste groups, and other demographics of gender and age, the new team reflects the BJP's attempts at a reset as the exigencies of three terms in power kick in.

nistula.hebbar@thehindu.co.in



BJP national president Nitin Nabin (seen folding his hands) receives a floral welcome upon his arrival to attend the party's State executive committee meeting, in Haldwani; he is joined by Uttarakhand Chief Minister Pushkar Singh Dhami (left). PTI



Director's cut Pratik Gandhi, Ishita Dutta and Tigmanshu Dhulia on the sets of the film. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



villages. So, when so much is happening in the world, why should I watch your love stories?," he says. Tigmanshu is picky about other genres too. "I don't watch every Hindi movie," he says. He has not seen some of Arshad Warsi's popular comedy films like the *Golmaal* series or *Hungama*. That is what made him look at Arshad differently when he decided to cast the actor as a dreaded dacoit in *Ghamasaan*. "I had seen him in *Sehar* and, of course, in *Munna Bhai MBBS*. So, I never looked at him as a comedian. I knew he is a very accomplished actor," says Tigmanshu.

The theatre training Casting Pratik Gandhi was simpler, as the director had earlier worked with him on the mystery-thriller series, *The Great Indian Murder*. "I know his background in theatre, and I wanted someone who could improvise. I had a lot of faith in him and he suited the part pretty well too," says Tigmanshu. The *Scam 1992* and *Madgaon Express* actor maintains stunning restraint as an IPS officer in *Ghamasaan*, who is tasked with chasing the hyper-violent Maharaj (Arshad Warsi). Pratik instils an ordinariness in his performance, a quality that he uses to humanise all

his characters. "I like minimalism a lot, with which you can communicate something that is written and anything that is not written as well. I like to give the audience a chance to interpret. That's what I like about the actor's life," Pratik says.

Tigmanshu adds that an actor has to rise above the lines. "Dialogue delivery is not acting. What the person thinks before saying a line, that's acting," he says.

The minimalism reflected in Pratik's performance has also been a definitive factor in the films of Tigmanshu – whether he gets into serious territory, like in his 2011 crime thriller *Shagird*, or goes pulpier, like in *Saheb, Biwi Aur Gangster* (2011). The same restraint is seen in *Ghamasaan*, where Tigmanshu relies more on the urgency of situations than on dramatic overtones. The filmmaker says he likes watching and making movies with those aesthetics. "It is easy to make hyper-dramatic films with loud background music, blood and butchery. I don't like to make my films that way," he says.

Ghamasaan takes an old-school approach in how it operates without the usual tropes and still manages to engage to a large extent. An important action sequence midway functions without reliance on any background score, which further accentuates the after-effects of violence. "It is the lull before the storm which is terrifying. There were moments like that even in *Sholay*, where suspense was created with just the sound of footsteps," he says. The actor opines that the change in storytelling in recent years reflects a lack of confidence that makers have in their work. "I have been seeing these days that, by design, we are creating second-screen experiences. We are scared of pauses and are filling it up with voice-overs and music because we feel the audience will go away." Tigmanshu agrees. "If you make a good film, people will watch," he says.

Ghamasaan is streaming on Zee5

A minimalistic approach

How director Tigmanshu Dhulia and actor Pratik Gandhi shaped their latest film, *Ghamasaan*

Shreyas Pande
shreyas.pande@thehindu.co.in

“I find love stories too boring,” declares Tigmanshu Dhulia during a freewheeling conversation about his latest film, *Ghamasaan*. The filmmaker's voice carries a frustration similar to his much-quoted dismissal of cinema as the infamous Ramadhir Singh from Anurag Kashyap's *Gangs of Wasseyapur*. And like Ramadhir, Tigmanshu is excited by the world of crime and politics, something he has explored right from his first film, *Haasil*. With *Ghamasaan*, he returns to the world of dacoits, which he

approached earlier with an earthy realism in *Paan Singh Tomar*. When asked what continues to attract him to this landscape, Tigmanshu is quick to chime in. “*Mera Mangal bohut strong hai* (I have a strong Mars in my horoscope),” he says, smiling, and explains that he is approached only to make films about dacoits and cops. “I have been an admirer of these films since I was a kid. If I was not a filmmaker, I would have been in the Army or police.” Tigmanshu feels that there is a lot to explore in characters living in the hinterland. “I don't find urban characters as interesting, as people are not facing such conflicts in cities. Your surname doesn't matter here as much, but it is different in

STEP OUT



Chocolate culture

Chocolate takes on a new format as Manam Chocolate opens its first standalone beverage bar in Delhi, bringing its Indian craft chocolate into drinks, gelato, pastries and savouries. The 200 sq. ft. island bar offers more than 24 hot and cold chocolate beverages, shakes, and plant-based and protein-forward options, alongside a Craft Your Own Beverage experience. The menu ranges from malted chocolate chai and dark chocolate orange to iced tiramisu latte and breakfast shake. The beverage bar is now open at DLF Promenade, New Delhi.



Faces in art

Faces become more than portraits in HEADS – Every Face Holds a Story, a group exhibition exploring identity, memory, and imagination. Curated by Amrita Kochhar, the show brings together artists including Anjolie Ela Menon, Jogen Chowdhury, Krishen Khanna, Thota Vaikuntam and others. On view until September 23, at Shridharani Gallery, Triveni Kala Sangam, from 11am to 8pm.

Play it by ear

At a three-day music retreat in Jaipur music turns into an experience that extends beyond the daily

Sangita Rajan
sangitarajan.pb@thehindu.co.in

In a world of playlists, earbuds and music consumed between meetings, commutes and scrolling, the India Music Retreat asks for something increasingly rare: time. For three days in Jaipur, over 400 people will put aside the usual hurry, and listen to music across the day in relaxed, informal spaces that lets them be present. The premise is less about attending a festival than entering a slower, more immersive relationship with music. “There are festivals happening all the time, public concerts, auditoriums, sabhas in Chennai. But how do you create a relationship with music which is more intense, an exchange of energy between the musician and the audience? How do you create an experience which is 360 degrees, where people experience it together and create a relationship that is for a lifetime?,” these are the questions Mala Sekhri, founder, India Music Retreat, answered before the idea came to her. That experiment would eventually evolve into the India Music Retreat, now in its second edition. Set to take place at Fairmont Jaipur from September 18 to 21, the retreat will bring together

musicians including Aruna Sairam, Shahid Parvez Khan, Ashwini Bhide Deshpande and Jasbir Jassi, alongside conversations, intimate performances and shared listening experiences spread across the property. “Our music is not meant to be confined to auditoriums. It needs atmosphere, *mahol*, vibe,” she says. The idea that music is shaped as much by its surroundings as by the performance itself, sits at the heart of the retreat's programming. “Today what is at a premium? Time. The fact that these are 400 people who come and give you three days of their lives is something I value deeply. Because today people can give anything. They can go anywhere, but they don't give you time,” she says, adding that she sees the retreat's audience not merely as consumers of music but as potential patrons who can sustain artistes beyond the stage. For Mala, the success of curation lies not just in assembling a strong lineup, but in building enough trust for audiences to arrive without knowing exactly what, or who, they are going to hear. The retreat deliberately puts established musicians alongside artists who may be unfamiliar to its audience, with discovery becoming part of the experience.



Musical meetup Saxophonist George Brooks at the previous edition of India Music Retreat. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Evolving art (Left) Manjunath Kamath, Around the White Fountain; (below) art at the Travancore Palace. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Canvas of change

Sakshi Gallery brings together 46 artists who examine how India's visual vocabulary has shifted alongside its social and political landscape

Geetika Sachdev

A Kashmiri house stands at the entrance to Sakshi Gallery's 40th anniversary exhibition, *Of Being and Becoming*, in Delhi's Travancore Palace. The installation's familiar architectural form is interrupted by shrapnel, skulls and fragments, while mirrors multiply the image of destruction around it. In Veer Munshi's *Echoes Without Borders*, a memory of home becomes a meditation on displacement and the recurring violence of war. It is an arresting way to enter an exhibition, and an indication of what follows. The show does not simply look back at the artists the gallery has represented, or assemble a selection of its most recognisable works. Instead, curator Manan Shah uses the occasion to ask how Indian contemporary art arrived at the visual language we see today, and what, along the way, changed it. The exhibition brings together 46 artists across generations, including Vivan Sundaram, Gulam Mohammed Sheikh, Nalini Malani, Rekha Rodwittiya, KG

Subramanyan, Navjot Altaf, Shilpa Gupta, Thukral and Tagra and others. Paintings, sculpture, video, installation and projection are brought into conversation across three sections spanning the late 1980s to the present. “When I was looking at the archive of Sakshi, they had done over 600 exhibitions,” says Manan. “Some of them were exceptional names to include. But I excluded them simply because they did not align with the premise of the show.” That premise is the changing visual grammar of the last four decades. Rather than simply declaring that art has become more political, conceptual or experimental, Manan wants the works themselves to demonstrate how and why those shifts occurred.

Changing vocabularies The exhibition unfolds like a theatre production, divided into three scenes: the late 1980s to 1999, the early 2000s to 2014, and 2014 to the present. The structure allows artists from different generations to sit alongside one another, with older and newer works sometimes placed almost in

direct conversation. The first section looks at a period when artists were moving away from formal conventions towards more narrative, conceptual and socially engaged practices. Manan points to two events in particular as significant: the economic reforms of 1991 and the demolition of the Babri Masjid in 1992. Both altered the social and political landscape, and, in turn, the concerns and visual strategies of artists. Works by Vivan Sundaram, Gulam Mohammed Sheikh and others reflect this transition. Elsewhere, in Rekha Rodwittiya's *In Search of My Mother's Garden*, personal memory becomes a point of departure for a wider feminist vocabulary. By the late 1990s and early 2000s, Manan identified another shift, towards what he calls “political minimalism”. Political concerns remain, but they increasingly arrive through fragments, satire and metaphor rather than direct representation. That quality runs through much of the later work. A sculpture by Sunil Gawde that initially resembles a floral garland reveals

itself to be made of blades. The viewer is repeatedly asked to look again. Manan sees this movement towards indirectness as one of the significant changes in contemporary visual practice, particularly after 2014, when concerns around surveillance, censorship, protest and political identity began to surface in increasingly layered ways. The political can also enter through reinterpretation. In Vivek Vilasini's *Last Supper* – Gaza, Leonardo da Vinci's familiar composition is recast through contemporary realities of faith, conflict and betrayal. The arrangement of figures echoes the original grouping of Christ and the apostles, but the historical image is made to speak to a present marked by war and political violence. The architecture of Travancore Palace becomes part of this story too. Rather than treating the historic building as a neutral container, Manan has retained its arches and character, while several artists have responded directly to the space. Riyas Komu's *Walking Towards the National Museum II* considers walking as both procession and retreat, while young artist Salik Ansari's large-scale installation *Altar of Celebrations* looks at celebration and the violence that can lie beneath it. By the end, even the familiar feels worth questioning.

The exhibition is on till September 20, at Travancore Palace, 11am to 6pm.

A fear of political fallout has led to an overly complex MDR structure on UPI

The government has also instructed banks to make sure that merchants do not pass on this charge to customers. But it has not specified how banks are expected to check whether merchants tweak their prices to absorb this additional charge. A back-of-the-envelope calculation based on past trends suggests that the MDR will yield an upper limit of ₹2,400 crore of monthly revenue for the payments ecosystem. The sector-wise flat rates and reduced rates will likely result in a lower amount. The government has denied any U.S. pressure to bring these rates to favour American credit card companies. Yet, the data suggest that the benefit will largely accrue to private banks and U.S.-owned UPI apps. There is still an argument to be made for the Reserve Bank of India to foot this bill from the vast surpluses it generates every year. Maintaining vital payment infrastructure is surely a good use of these funds. However, if the government persists in implementing this charge, it should certainly simplify the structure. There is still time before its rollout. The Goods and Services Tax experience shows that rate complexity hits small businesses the hardest.

Manipur's new Kuki-Zo-Naga conflict needs firm, even-handed State action

Yet, these moves have coincided with a new ethnic fault line in Manipur. Since February, violence between the Naga and Kuki-Zo communities – which began as localised disputes – has spread across the hill districts. Till July, at least 15 Kuki-Zo people, 11 Nagas, three security personnel and a truck driver were killed; more have died in the last two months. Houses in Naga and Kuki-Zo villages have been burnt down and the newly displaced have moved into camps. Blockades imposed by partisans of the communities against the other have held up essentials and medicines, with the smaller Kuki-Zo community the worse affected. Health centres in the hills have been left dysfunctional. This echoes the Naga-Kuki violence of the 1990s, now revived by armed groups claiming to act on behalf of their respective communities and resurrecting arguments over who controls the hills and whose customary laws prevail there. With its tenure ending soon and Assembly elections due next year, the State government must move quickly to contain this outbreak of hostilities. It must work with civil society to lower the rhetoric – reportage from the ground suggests a weariness with the violence across communities – while acting against the armed groups with the help of the security forces. Those imposing blockades must be deterred by the force of law. Criminal law must apply equally across communities in the hills, and the safety and welfare of civilians must be guaranteed irrespective of ethnicity.

The 2024 general election strongly indicates that the BJP had lost ground in U.P. Its tally fell from 62 seats in 2019 to 33, while the SP won 37 and the Congress six. The sharpest erosion occurred in Awadh, once the heartland of the Ayodhya temple movement. In 2022, the BJP won 101 of Awadh's 154 Assembly seats. In 2024, it was

Professor Emerita,
Centre for Political
Studies, Jawaharlal
Nehru University

The State's changing electoral landscape, marked by the BJP losing ground in 2024, raises questions about how long the party's political dominance can endure

The frustration among young voters is strikingly evident in the precarity of employment and recruitment. Many were actively involved in the anti-National Eligibility cum Entrance Test

The 2027 election will therefore reveal more than the BJP's ability to recover lost seats. It will show whether the political template that carried the party to power from Lucknow to New Delhi still commands the same electoral force. The 2024 result has already shown that this template is no longer invulnerable in U.P. The 2027 election will determine whether the shift revealed in 2024 becomes more durable. What happens in U.P. could therefore alter the political balance on which the BJP's national dominance has rested.

Former Permanent Representative of India to the United Nations and, currently, Dean, Kautilya School of Public Policy, Hyderabad

Washington sanctioned four companies based in India and three Indian nationals over alleged trade in Iranian oil and petrochemicals. Tehran listed an LNG carrier serving India and an Indian-flagged bulk carrier for possible fines, detention or confiscation in the Strait of Hormuz. One order travels through bank wires; the other waits at sea.

American laws in the 1990s threatened foreign companies with penalties for conduct abroad. Europe responded with a Blocking Statute. When secondary sanctions against Iran returned in 2018, several European companies withdrew despite having legal protection at home. The possible loss of access to American banking and dollar payments was enough to choke off trade

A coordinated response is essential as sanctions increasingly target entire transactions

That coordination should survive the crisis. An Economic Security and Sanctions Office under the Cabinet Secretariat should become India's permanent war room for economic coercion. It should bring together officials responsible for foreign policy, finance, commerce, energy, shipping, law and defence, alongside the Reserve

India also needs more LPG storage, an expanded Indian-controlled tanker fleet and a stronger Bharat Maritime Insurance Pool, while securing long-term LNG contracts outside Hormuz. Rupee settlement can preserve lawful trade when sellers accept it, but cannot shield a bank that still needs New York.

The first test of sovereignty happens when Delhi decides. The second comes when that decision meets a New York bank or the Strait of Hormuz. In the age of sanctions, India cannot move those chokepoints. It can, however, make sure that every decision is taken with the whole journey in view.

ally in combating climate change. There must be greater awareness of the work of premier institutions such as India's Forest Research Centre for Bamboo and Rattan (FRCBR), in Aizawl, Mizoram.

M. Pradyu,
Thalikkavu, Kannur, Kerala

Letters emailed to
letters@thehindu.co.in
must carry the postal address.

The concerns being expressed by some technology companies that artificial intelligence (AI) poses a threat to humanity cannot be ignored. There is no doubt that AI is making significant advances in critical sectors. Nevertheless, the possibility of its misuse by anti-national or anti-social

forces cannot be ruled out. At a time when cybercrimes are frequently reported, the abuse of AI in cyberspace could cause irreparable damage to society. The technology companies promoting AI must also provide a safety net to protect the global community from possible AI-related threats. Though superintelligence could be a

Deserving Phalke awardee
Veteran Kannada actor Anant Nag richly deserves the Dadasaheb Phalke award. His effortless acting and flawless diction in

On World Bamboo Day, September 18, it is worth recognising a remarkable

plant that holds immense cultural and ecological value. Known variously as 'green gold' and 'poor man's timber', bamboo is an environmental powerhouse, with more than 1,500 species capable of thriving in diverse climates. Globally, bamboo is deeply woven into human traditions. Beyond its well-established traditional uses, it is a vital

ally in combating climate change. There must be greater awareness of the work of premier institutions such as India's Forest Research Centre for Bamboo and Rattan (FRCBR), in Aizawl, Mizoram.

M. Pradyu,
Thalikkavu, Kannur, Kerala

Does the BRICS summit signify a shift for Indian foreign policy?



Ajay Bisaria
served as High Commissioner to Pakistan and Canada and is the author of 'Anger Management: The Troubled Diplomatic Relationship Between India and Pakistan'

PARLEY

With a strong pushback against unilateral western sanctions; criticism of Israel over the killing of civilians, the attacks on Lebanon, and the forced occupation of Palestinian territory; and support for UN reform as well as a BRICS payment mechanism, the New Delhi Declaration of 2026 has been likened to India's foreign policy from its non-aligned past. But was it a compromise by New Delhi to build consensus, or will the statement, and Prime Minister Narendra Modi's close engagement with the leaders of Iran, Russia, and China, have a bearing on India's foreign policy? Ajay Bisaria and Happymon Jacob discuss the question in a conversation moderated by **Suhasini Haidar**.

Is the New Delhi declaration a return to non-alignment or just momentary rhetoric?

Ajay Bisaria: Broadly, the declaration is in keeping with India's foreign policy, whether that is strategic autonomy and multi-alignment or multi-vector engagement. In terms of optics, India is more on the front foot and less apologetic than it used to be. India is getting more and more comfortable in a non-western forum, saying that it is emphatically part of it. While it doesn't necessarily mean a shift in posture, it does suggest a greater degree of comfort with a different set of optics.

Happymon Jacob: The BRICS summit is under spotlight and things under spotlight look bigger and shinier than they really are. BRICS is a political platform; not a security platform. I don't think India's policy today is that of non-alignment at all. Non-alignment was a strategy for a weak state in a bipolar world. Today, we are in a different kind of world and the desire in India is to become one of the poles in a multipolar world. There is a reference to the Bandung Spirit (Non-Aligned Movement) in the BRICS declaration in pursuit of a fairer, more inclusive, and representative multilateral system. But that is nostalgia, not real policy.

How important are optics such as the Modi-Xi-Putin handshakes or the Prime Minister reaching out to the Iranian President at a time when these leaders represent the "anti-Western lobby"?

HJ: The optics are, in some ways, the substance here. Chinese President Xi Jinping had not been to India in nearly seven years. And we had the Abu Dhabi Crown Prince (Khaled bin Zayed Al Nahyan) sitting at the same table. In some ways, the photograph is the message. At the BRICS



Russia's President Vladimir Putin, Prime Minister Narendra Modi, and China's President Xi Jinping pose with other leaders during the BRICS Summit. AFP

outreach session, a lot of powers who don't otherwise get into great power conversations were present. So, there was a lot of socialisation happening inside the platform and on its margins. But I think we should understand that this is not really having an impact on how the world is being shaped. The declaration calls for exercising restraint and protecting civilians and civilian infrastructure and pointedly recalls the respective national positions of each member. It is fantastic, but the argument here is about optics, not common positions.

AB: I would agree that these multilateral fora are often performative to a degree and therefore all optics matter. But in a multilateral document, you can say the silent part aloud; what a country won't say in a national statement, it can say aloud in a high-level multilateral summit. For instance, everyone knows that the phrase "unilateral coercive measures" is about U.S. actions. So, you're not really saying we condemn U.S. action on so-and-so date; you're simply saying that we are against U.S. tariffs and [western] sanctions. There is an understanding now that what is said in a multilateral document can be different from a national position.

Every BRICS summit since 2022, including the 2024 summit in Russia, has made a reference to Ukraine. The New Delhi Declaration is the first time that references to Ukraine have been dropped. Why?

AB: My guess would be that it was a Russian veto. In the Rio BRICS declaration last year, there was even condemnation of a Ukrainian attack on Russia without an equivalent condemnation of anything Russia had done. So this time, instead of just condemning Ukraine, they might have decided to drop the whole thing entirely. It is very disappointing that a major multilateral geopolitical forum doesn't call for belligerents to end the war, but instead stays silent. That is an error of omission. I suspect the



Broadly, the Delhi declaration is in keeping with India's foreign policy, whether that is strategic autonomy and multi-alignment or multi-vector engagement

AJAY BISARIA

Russians said, no, we don't accept it, and in the interest of having a consensus, it was dropped.

HJ: I think India has no particular reason to push for that language to be present in the declaration because we have quite clearly sided with the Russian Federation in this war, indirectly if not directly. There must have been Russian push but I see no reason why there could not have been some neutral language to put in [references to Ukraine], given the precedent (of previous BRICS joint declarations).

The condemnation of Israel in the statement is very strong. Does this represent a shift for India given the PM's speech on standing "shoulder to shoulder" with Israel during his visit in February 2026?

AB: The big picture is that India is trying to establish neutral and balanced positions on both conflicts, and therefore not be seen as backing only one side in either. It has taken safety in the language of the United Nations. There's a specific mention of the UN Security Council Resolution 2803 of November last year, which spoke about an International Stabilisation Force and a Board of Peace. Some of the language has been drawn from there. The overall posture is: let's try to be balanced and reasonably neutral.

HJ: There is a clear disjunction between the statement and what Prime Minister Modi told the Israeli parliament. Perhaps the declaration is in some way intended to counter the perception that India was getting too close to Israel. The two-state solution has always been India's position, so the declaration doesn't contradict Indian policy there. But with the UAE, Egypt, Iran, and Indonesia in the room, there was only so much India could do to push back against the harshness of that language. What Prime Minister Modi told the Israelis in Israel is emotional and consequential. But what is written in the BRICS Declaration is multilateral, symbolic, and not very consequential. I would still say the balance is tilted in favour of Israel as a partner.

How significant are the paragraphs on economic issues, particularly on intra-BRICS trade using payments in national currencies? These 10 or 11 countries represent 40% of the

global economy, and 25% of global trade. Could they pose a challenge to the G7?

HJ: Indian policy has two parts. One is the support for local currency payment mechanisms. I don't think India has supported a permanent payment mechanism under the ambit of BRICS. I think there is an acknowledgement that there is no one-size-fits-all approach as far as currency settlement payment mechanisms are concerned. I would think twice before signing on to a non-U.S. dollar payment mechanism, which I believe will mean the next big currency or the next powerful currency. And unfortunately, China's currency is going to be that big currency.

AB: BRICS is a counterpoint to the G7, an economic grouping that also has geopolitical responsibilities. But I think India also finds itself at an intersection with the G7, because it is a sort of permanent invitee to the G7, along with Australia and South Korea. I have made the argument elsewhere that the G7 should dissolve itself and become the Democratic 10 (D10), including these three countries. I think that is the real strategic autonomy or multi-vector engagement, where India becomes the bridge between the east and the west, but also a voice of the south.

Will any of the decisions at BRICS see their way into future Indian foreign policy? Or is this just one moment with BRICS countries?

AB: I think this is a moment of success in Indian diplomacy in terms of conducting a major international event. In November, there will be another opportunity to meet global leaders at the ASEAN-East Asia Summit in the Philippines, followed by Prime Minister Modi's visits to the U.S., Canada, and Brussels, where he could potentially secure three trade agreements. I think that's what diplomacy will be about: multi-vector engagement; keeping all stakeholders engaged, in multiple directions.

HJ: India has only so much diplomatic capital. Therefore, it is important to pick our battles, forums, and partners. I think we should be present in those rooms where global rules on AI are being framed, and where the future of space governance is discussed. I don't think the next world order is going to be made in forums such as the BRICS but in those silent small rooms.



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NOTEBOOK

AI makes editors read the writer as well as the text

Editors are often caught between their duty to the readers and employers and the demands of the publishing process

Vasudevan Mukunth

I'm a commissioning editor. Every day, I receive more submissions of articles written by AI than the last. The same goes for articles polished by AI. More than going against *The Hindu's* policy, this habit has the potential to corrode the human practice of writing.

Writing is often hard. You consider the relationship between your intentions and the meaning of words laid down on a page. You think through using the many degrees of freedom a sentence or paragraph affords to convey precisely what you mean, down to the feeling, while also holding readers' attention and doing justice to yourself without becoming self-absorbed. Writing should trouble the mind. AI-made or -polished writing offers to take this trouble away – a temptation to be resisted.

AI-written or -polished text can be corrosive to readers as well because all such texts, no matter how diverse their contents, read the same way. Editing it to be more human, to have an undulating rhythm rather than that sterilised glaze, is also an exasperating experience.

I used to maintain a list of the hallmarks of AI-written or -polished text, but as they evolved, I turned to two 'detector' tools: GPTZero and Pangram. I trust them because of their favourable coverage in the scientific press, their developers' attitude towards the tools' role in the publishing enterprise, and their lower false-positive rates. A false positive is when a tool flags a piece as being AI-written when in reality it is not. It can be pernicious because it causes me to decline a submission I may have accepted, potentially disappointing an author. Such a result may also cause editors to develop an unfavourable opinion of such contributors.

Sometimes, these tools jointly return very high or very low scores, allowing me to decide quickly about accepting or declining submissions. The problem arises when one or both tools return a middling score, e.g. "50% chance of being written by AI" or "50% of the text is written by AI".

In these instances, I need to negotiate a way forward. If the author is a rookie, I may insist on seeing the timestamped version history of the document containing their text, and ensure the words didn't suddenly appear all at once. (If I have doubts at the time of commissioning itself, I may insist the author quote some experts firsthand and submit their reporting notes together with the finished article.) If I have a mature relationship with an author, I directly communicate the stakes and possible courses of action.

But when an author doesn't tick these convenient boxes, I need to draft a reply that balances several sensibilities. First, I must not offend them. In fact, I have no intention of villainising them: people use AI models with text for various reasons, only a small subset of which are malicious. Second, I need to elicit from the author an honest response about whether, and if so how, they used AI – especially a reply I can be sure is unencumbered by insecurities or second-guessing. Third, I need to keep the author's trust while maintaining that I cannot accept AI-written or -polished text. Fourth, I must justify, if required, my decision to repose my trust in those tools rather than in my judgment and/or in our relationship alone.

Now, if GPTZero and Pangram independently falsely flag 5 out of every 100 articles as being AI-written or -polished, they will have a combined false positive rate of just 1 in 4 million. However, the chance of one tool flagging an article right and the other flagging it wrong is still 1 in 1,000, which is much higher.

But I cannot make decisions with mathematics alone as my guide. AI has caused me to think more closely about the author submitting an article and their reasons to use – or not use – AI. Similarly, it would help if authors think more closely about editors, who are caught between their duty to their readers and employers on one hand and to facilitate the publishing process on the other.

mukunth.v@thehindu.co.in

PICTURE OF THE WEEK

Chasing the sunset



Golden hour: Trained swimmers accompany a Ganesha idol which is to be immersed in the Krishna River downstream of the Prakasam Barrage in Vijayawada, Andhra Pradesh following the Ganesh Chaturthi festivities on September 16. The immersion was carried out at a designated stretch of the river. G.N. RAO

FROM THE ARCHIVES

FIFTY YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 18, 1976

Bright future for computers in India

Hyderabad, September 17: Prof. A.S. Douglas, Professor of Computational Methods, London School of Economics and Vice-President, International Federation of Information Processing told *The Hindu* here to-day that computer technology would have considerable future in developing countries like India as it aided the planning process in various spheres. He said that computers could be used for highly sophisticated calculations in

The Hindu.

scientific and technical matters as well as simple calculations in physics and chemistry.

Prof. Douglas said that while there were certain jobs which could be done efficiently by men, there were many things which computers could perform more efficiently and quickly than human beings. It was necessary that a happy balance should be maintained in the choice of jobs that could be performed by men and those that could be entrusted to computers.

Prof. Douglas, who was delivering a lecture under the auspices of the Hyderabad Chapter of the Computer Society of India, said that India should have a well-organised programme for the training of personnel needed for manning the computers.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 18, 1926

A lecture on advertising

Under the auspices of the Students' Economical Association the inaugural address was delivered yesterday evening by Prof. Jospeh France of the Presidency College, in the Senate House. The meeting was well attended. The Chairman in his opening remarks said that India was lacking in the art of advertisements. Owing to the neglect of this branch of study most of the Indian industries were not well-known. Best of their products found no place in the advertising field, whereas they found so many minor products of the west advertised through newspapers.

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Increase in Indian utilities’ August coal imports

5.52 million metric tonnes. Indian power producers’ coal imports in August rose to a 15-month high as a heatwave and lower hydropower generation boosted electricity demand. Coal imports jumped 85.6% year-on-year to 5.52 million metric tonnes. REUTERS

Number of deceased persons returned to Ukraine by Russia

252 Ukraine has received the bodies of 252 people in an exchange of war dead with Russia, Ukrainian authorities said on Thursday. Russia received 23 bodies in return, Russian lawmaker Shamsail Saraliev was quoted as saying by the RBK news outlet. AFP

Private capital attracted by the World Bank

112 in \$ billion. The World Bank on Thursday said it attracted \$112 billion in private capital in the year ended June versus \$69 billion a year earlier, and more than triple the amount in fiscal 2022 before former Mastercard CEO Ajay Banga became president. REUTERS

Amount to be spent on defence by Ukraine in 2027

4.9 in trillion hryvnia. The Ukrainian government plans to spend two-thirds of its budget on defence next year. Russia’s four-and-a-half-year offensive has battered Ukraine’s economy, causing billions of dollars in destruction and punching a huge hole in its neighbour’s finances. AFP

Number of taluks declared drought-hit in Karnataka

124 The Karnataka government on Thursday declared 23 more taluks drought-affected, taking the total number of drought-hit taluks notified so far to 124, amid dry conditions in several parts of the State. PTI
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What is the Uniform Civil Code debate?

How are personal laws governed today? What does the Constitution say about a UCC? What are the arguments in favour of a UCC? What are the arguments against? How could a UCC guarantee equal women’s rights? What alternative has been proposed?

EXPLAINER

Rangarajan R.

The story so far:

Union Home Minister Amit Shah has indicated that the Uniform Civil Code (UCC) would be implemented in all 21 NDA-ruled States by 2029. Uttarakhand has had a UCC in force since January 2025, while UCC bills passed by the legislatures of Assam, Gujarat and Madhya Pradesh are awaiting Presidential assent.

How are personal matters governed today?

Article 44 of the Constitution provides that the State shall endeavour to secure a UCC for citizens throughout India. A UCC would apply the same set of secular personal laws to all people, irrespective of religion, caste, or tribe. India already has uniform criminal laws and common civil laws covering matters such as taxation, contracts, and negotiable instruments.

However, in matters such as marriage, divorce, and inheritance of property, various religious communities in India follow personal laws that are based on their religious doctrines. Hindus are governed by laws such as the Hindu Marriage Act (1955) and the Hindu Succession Act (1956), while many tribals within the Hindu religion may follow customary family laws under constitutional exceptions. Jains, Buddhists and Sikhs are covered by Hindu laws. Sikh marriages can also be registered under the Anand Marriage Act (2012). Christians and Parsis have their own personal laws, while Muslims are governed by the Muslim Personal Law (Shariat) Application Act (1937).

What are the pros and cons?

The Constitution makers were divided over including a UCC in the Constitution.



GETTY IMAGES

Some wanted it to be made a Fundamental Right to ensure uniformity in civil laws and secure equal rights for women. However, many members of the Muslim community were not in favour of including it in the Constitution as they felt that a uniform civil code would violate the fundamental right to religion that is guaranteed in Part III. Finally, the provision relating to UCC was placed in the non-justiciable Part IV - Directive Principles of State Policy.

There are several arguments over aspects of the UCC. The key arguments in its favour are, first, that it would make India secular in the true sense by subjecting all citizens to the same personal laws. The second and most vital argument is gender justice: a UCC would ensure equal rights for women across religions in matters governed by personal laws.

The key arguments against UCC are as follows. First, there can be potential conflict between the provisions of the UCC and guaranteed fundamental rights. Article 25 of the Constitution guarantees every person a fundamental right to practise a religion of one’s choice. Article 29 provides a fundamental right to any section of citizens to conserve their distinct culture. The provisions of a UCC on personal matters may run contrary to scriptures and cultural doctrines in a religion. Second, the four States that have enacted UCC have exempted tribal population from its ambit. The reasons for such exemption are constitutional safeguards to protect tribal culture as well as the belief that many tribal customs in these matters provide adequate rights to women. However, exempting one section of society while making it compulsory for all other groups, including religious

minorities, is discriminatory.

What can be the way forward?

The most important reason to reform civil laws is to ensure equal rights for women in matters of marriage, divorce, maintenance, and inheritance. The right to religion under Article 25 is subject to constitutional morality and other fundamental rights, including equality. In Section 6A of the Citizenship Act, 1955 (2024) case, the Supreme Court held that practices such as casteism and gender discrimination, which run against the spirit of the Constitution, would not receive protection under Article 29. Thus, reforms in personal laws should not be viewed as violating Articles 25 and 29, as they uphold women’s equality, an essential facet of constitutional morality.

However, there is resistance to the UCC among minorities, particularly Muslims. In the Constituent Assembly, Dr. B.R. Ambedkar advocated a UCC but suggested that it could remain voluntary. He said Parliament could provide for the UCC to apply to citizens who declare they are willing to be bound by it.

On the other hand, the Law Commission in its Consultation Paper on Reform of Family Law (2018) opined that a UCC was neither necessary nor desirable at this stage. It argued instead for reforming discriminatory provisions across personal laws. The emphasis should be on achieving ‘equality within communities’ between men and women rather than ‘equality between communities.’ The report recommends legislative reforms required in various personal laws with respect to marriage, divorce, custody, adoption, maintenance, succession and inheritance, that would ensure gender justice. The suggestions of the Law Commission should be considered while legislating and implementing reforms in personal laws. (Rangarajan R is a former IAS officer and author of ‘Courseware on Polity Simplified’. Views expressed are personal)

THE GIST

▼ The Uniform Civil Code (UCC) would replace religion-based personal laws governing matters such as marriage, divorce and inheritance with a common set of secular laws

▼ Supporters argue that it would promote secularism, national integration and gender justice, while critics point to possible conflicts with religious and cultural rights

▼ The Law Commission has instead favoured reforming discriminatory provisions in existing personal laws to ensure equality between men and women

Why was ex-Kosovo President convicted by The Hague?

What was Thaci’s role in the Kosovo Liberation Army? How has the verdict been received?

Joan Sony Cherian

The story so far:

Hashim Thaci, the former President of Kosovo, has been sentenced to 25 years in prison after being found guilty of war crimes by a special European Union-backed court at The Hague. The trial found him guilty of war crimes including murder, arbitrary detention, illegal arrests, torture, etc during the Kosovo war in the late 1990s as a senior commandant of the Kosovo Liberation Army (KLA). Three other former KLA commanders were also sentenced for several different charges.

What happened?

Thaci was a former commandant of the KLA, a militant ethnic Albanian force, formed in the early 1990s, which strove for the independence of Kosovo, composed primarily of ethnic Albanians, from Yugoslavia and Serbia.

Kosovo was once part of the erstwhile Republic of Yugoslavia. After the Second World War, the Kingdom of Yugoslavia

was reconstituted as the Socialist Federal Republic of Yugoslavia under the leadership of Josip Broz Tito. While Tito was able to unify the multiple republics, including Croatia, Montenegro, Serbia, Slovenia, Bosnia and Herzegovina, and Macedonia, and the autonomous provinces of Kosovo and Vojvodina, under a centralised government, the system came under pressure after his death. Multiple factors, including divisions between the republics, rising nationalist movements, economic pressures, and the disintegration of the Soviet Union, contributed to Yugoslavia’s eventual dissolution in 2003.

One of the primary nationalist trends that spearheaded Yugoslavian dissolution was the Serbian nationalist movement led by Slobodan Milošević in the late 1980s. Riding on Serbian nationalist tendencies, Milošević pushed through policies that stripped other republics and provinces, such as Kosovo, of their autonomy. He also brought in policies that were discriminatory in nature against Albanians.

The KLA was formed in this

atmosphere to fight for the independence of ethnic Albanians in Kosovo, then a province within Serbia. The KLA led an insurgency against the Yugoslav state, attacking Serbian government buildings and police stations. This eventually led to an all-out war in 1998-1999, with the Serbian-controlled federal republic brutally cracking down on the KLA. The war led to the displacement of thousands of people and the death of nearly 13,000 people, mostly ethnic Albanians. The war finally ended with the intervention of NATO (the North Atlantic Treaty Organization), which carried out air raids and bombardments against Serbian targets, which forced the federal republic to end hostilities and move out of Kosovo. NATO subsequently deployed peacekeeping forces to the region.

Milošević eventually stood trial for his crimes against humanity, genocide, and war crimes committed during the Yugoslav Wars of the 1990s, in The Hague in 2002. However, he died in prison before a judgment was reached.

In 2008, Kosovo declared independence from Serbia and was

recognised by the U.S. and several other European nations. However, Serbia does not recognise Kosovo as an independent nation and still considers it a part of itself even though it has no administrative control over it. It is still not a member state of the UN. India also does not recognise Kosovo as an independent nation.

What was the trial for?

The trial was heard by the European Union-backed Kosovo Specialist Chambers, a special tribunal court constituted in The Hague in 2016, to hear the crimes committed by the KLA during the period of insurgency and subsequent war of the 1990s. The need for such a tribunal arose after Swiss politician Dick Marty authored a Council of Europe report, known as the Marty report, in 2010, which alleged that the KLA placed many Serbians in secret detention centres where they were subjected to inhuman and degrading treatment, before ultimately “disappearing”. Of particular note was the allegation that the KLA had harvested the organs of such prisoners to sell them in the international market.

The report, in effect, coloured the larger imagination of the KLA and the Kosovo independence movement. The narrative changed from the KLA being seen as a champion of self-determination to an inhumane militia which had committed human rights abuses against Serbian nationals.

At least 15 people have been charged by the Chambers, with Thaci being the most senior figure. Charges were brought

against him in 2020, when he was President of Kosovo, following which he had to resign and stand trial as an ordinary citizen. The central question before the court was to understand the extent of the commandants’ control over the KLA and whether the crimes amounted to a pattern of abuse. Finally, presiding judge Charles Smith stated that Thaci had “actively participated in and encouraged crimes,” adding that “the scale and nature of the crimes committed were very serious”. However, the judge insisted that the trial was “not about the legitimacy of the Kosovo Liberation Army” or its ultimate goal of securing independence for Kosovo.

What has been the reaction?

The verdict is a significant fall for Thaci, who was once regarded by Western powers as central to Kosovo’s post-war future. In Kosovo, where Thaci is still seen as a revolutionary figure, the verdict was met with outrage and tears. Kosovo’s Prime Minister Albin Kurti said the verdict was “a travesty of justice”. People who had poured into the streets of Pristina, the capital of Kosovo, to hear the verdict were shocked and shouted slogans in support of the KLA and Thaci.

However, the Serbian side has welcomed the judgement. Serbia’s Deputy Prime Minister Ivica Dacic called the verdicts a “warning” to Pristina “that a fake state cannot be built on mass graves of murdered Serbs”.

Thaci and the three other commandants have the right to appeal the decision.

EXPLAINER



Merchant Discount Rate is a fee for using UPI that will be paid by merchants to payment processors and banks. REUTERS

Who has to pay MDR on UPI and who stands to gain the most?

Merchant Discount Rate will apply to certain P2M transactions above ₹2,000, while P2P transactions and merchant payments up to ₹2,000 will remain free; the charge will be shared among banks and UPI apps, with exemptions and caps limiting the transactions and amount that attract MDR

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan

The story so far: After much speculation and debate, the National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI) has finally released its circular about the additional charges it will allow to be levied on certain UPI payments from October 15. While the Opposition has argued that this charge will increase prices for consumers, the government has argued that this will not happen, and that even the impact on merchants will be minimal.

Who will have to pay the MDR charge? Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) is a fee for using UPI that will be paid by merchants to payment processors and banks. Consumers will not have to directly pay the MDR. In its press release relating to the NPCI's announcement, the Ministry of Finance on September 15 emphasised that banks have been advised to ensure that merchants do not pass MDR charges on to customers and that UPI application providers are expressly prohibited from imposing platform fees or hidden charges on users.

The MDR will have to be paid by mid-to large-sized merchants who receive UPI payments in excess of ₹2,000 per transaction. These merchants will have to pay a charge of 0.4%. For transactions of ₹75,000 and above, the MDR will be capped at ₹300 per transaction.

However, the rules change when it comes to essential sectors. Transactions of ₹2,000 or more in essential and thin-margin sectors, such as railways, telecommunications, insurance, fuel, and agricultural inputs, will attract a flat MDR of ₹5 per transaction.

According to the government, this flat charge will provide cost certainty for critical public services and businesses operating on narrow margins. Further, capital market transactions such as payments to mutual funds, stockbrokers, dealers, and for equities will attract an MDR of 0.02%, capped at ₹300 per transaction. This lower rate, the government has argued, is aimed at supporting retail participation in formal financial markets.

One way to ascertain how widespread the charge will be is to look at the volumes of UPI transactions. An analysis by *The Hindu* of data provided by the NPCI shows that person-to-merchant (P2M) transactions above ₹2,000 make up just 2.5% of all UPI transactions by volume.

Who will not have to pay? All Person-to-Person (P2P) transactions will remain free of charge, regardless of the amount being transferred. The government has specified that “no transaction fee, platform fee or other charge may be imposed on individuals for sending or receiving money through UPI”. This is a significant exemption because P2P UPI transactions make up about 37% of the total UPI transaction volume.

Further, payments to merchants up to ₹2,000 will remain free of MDR. This makes up another 60.5% of all UPI transactions by volume. That means, in total, 97.5% of all UPI transactions will remain free.

In addition, the NPCI has mandated that small merchants, including street vendors receiving up to ₹1 lakh per month through UPI QR codes under the Person-to-Person-Merchant (P2PM) category, will also be exempt from MDR.

This means that the proportion of UPI payments that will attract a charge is actually even smaller than 2.5%.

Who stands to gain the most? The government has said that the MDR will be shared among payment ecosystem participants, including banks, payment service providers, and UPI application providers.

The analysis of the NPCI data shows that the P2M transactions above ₹2,000 make up 20% of all UPI transactions by value.

That is, while ₹29.8 lakh crore was transacted over UPI in August 2026, P2M transactions above ₹2,000 were ₹5.99 lakh crore. This means that the absolute maximum that banks and payment processors can earn from MDR is about ₹2,400 crore a month (0.4% of ₹5.99 lakh crore) or ₹28,000 crore a year. However, since there are multiple caveats, exemptions, flat rates, and caps imposed, the total amount receivable will be lower than this.

The way MDR works is that the bulk of

the charge (about 40% of what is collected) goes to the payer's bank since it holds the customer's bank account and bears the core authorisation, security, and settlement costs of the transaction.

Here, Yes Bank is the undisputed gainer, since it is the payer bank in more than 50% of all UPI transactions. The second largest is ICICI Bank at 18.3%.

Of the MDR collected, the merchant's bank or receiving bank receives 30%. This is because they manage the merchant's relationship, handle the QR code deployment, and process merchant settlements.

Here, too, Yes Bank is the payee in about 55% of all UPI transactions and so stands to earn the most from the MDR, followed by Axis Bank at about 19%.

Another 20% of the MDR goes to the UPI app or Third-Party Application Provider (TPAP). PhonePe and Google Pay stand to benefit from this, since PhonePe accounts for about 46% of UPI transactions by volume and Google Pay another 32%.

The final 10% of the MDR goes to the Payment Service Provider that connects the technology partner bank that connects the UPI application to the central network switches.

The government has also said that a dedicated fund will be established to promote UPI adoption among small merchants, with an amount equivalent to 5% of total MDR collections contributed to this fund. It does not specify from which of the payment system players this 5% will be taken.



FROM THE ARCHIVES

Know your English

S. Upendran

How do you refer to the years between 1901 and 1910? Is there a single word for it? (Subhkaran Choradia, Nagaur, Rajasthan) No, there isn't. There is no word to refer to something that happened in the first or the second decade of a particular century. People generally tend to say the 'early decades' of the Twentieth Century. We can, for example, say 'the early 1900s', or the first/second decade of the Twentieth Century. It is, however, possible to refer to something that happened after 1920. For example, the years between 1920 and 1930 are usually referred to as the 1920s. Similarly, we have the 1930s, 1940s, etc. If we know which century we are talking about, then we may simply say the 40s, the 50s, etc. It is important to note, however, that there is no apostrophe after the year. We do not generally write '1930's'; it would be wrong to do so.

What is a female "postmaster" called? (A. Ambar, Chennai) A woman who is in charge of a local post office is called a 'postmistress'. Makes sense, doesn't it? The plural is 'postmistresses'. These words have been included in the latest edition of some dictionaries. Ever wondered what a female postman is called? Logically, it should be 'postwoman', but none of the dictionaries have included this word. In the U.S., men and women who deliver mail are called "mail carriers".

What is the meaning of "stand someone up"? (V. S. Narayan, Kakinada) This is an expression which is frequently used in informal contexts. When you 'stand someone up', you make an appointment with the individual and then fail to show up. The expression is normally used when one fails to keep a date with one's boyfriend or girlfriend. If your boss doesn't keep his appointment, you don't generally say that the boss stood you up! Unless, of course, your boss happens to be your significant other. *Sunita stood Raju up. He was extremely angry.*

How is the word "roulette" pronounced? (B. Srinivasan, Chennai) The 'ou' in the first syllable is like the 'oo' in 'ool', 'pool', and 'cool', while the 'e' in the second syllable sounds like the 'e' in 'set', 'pet', and 'let'. The final 'e' is silent and the main stress is on the second syllable. Any idea what "roulette" is? It is a gambling game in which a wheel (roulette) spins round and round and you have to predict which number the ball or marble will land on. Then of course we have Russian roulette. Ever heard of this game? Well, it's not actually a game. What you do is put a bullet into one of the chambers of a gun, leaving the remaining five chambers empty. You then keep spinning the chambers till you are no longer sure where the bullet is. Next you place the gun on your head and pull the trigger. If you are lucky, you survive; otherwise....

Some people get a lot of thrill playing such games. Gabbar Singh in Sholay enjoyed playing Russian roulette. The expression 'playing Russian roulette' has begun to be used metaphorically as well. When you say that someone is 'playing Russian roulette', what you are implying is that he/she is taking terrible risks; doing something very, very dangerous. *Published in The Hindu on January 1, 2002*

Word of the day

Adulation: servile flattery; exaggerated and hypocritical praise

Synonyms: adoration, worship, appreciation, idolisation

Usage: *The actor received adulation from his fans.*

Pronunciation: newsth.live/adulation

International Phonetic Alphabet: /ədʒʊleɪʃən/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to letters@thehindu.co.in with the subject 'Text & Context'

THE DAILY QUIZ

Test yourself on the Indian odyssey at the Asian Games ahead of the 20th edition starting in Aichi-Nagoya on Saturday

V.V. Ramanan

- QUESTION 1**
It is well known that the Asian Games debuted in New Delhi in 1951. What is the only other time India has played host to the Games?
- QUESTION 2**
With a gold medal at every edition and 779 medals overall, India is the fifth-most successful country at the Games. In which Games did it cross the 100 medal mark with 107?
- QUESTION 3**
The most successful Indian athlete at the Games has 11 medals, including four golds at a single edition. Who and in which Games did the legend win four golds?

- QUESTION 4**
Mohamed Anas Imran Beg, Declan Marshall Gonsalves and Quimcy Dsouza are representing India in which sport that is making its debut in 2026?
- QUESTION 5**
In which sport has India been dominant, with the men winning eight out of the nine editions since the sport's debut in 1990 and the women four out of five since 2010?
- QUESTION 6**
Which sport follows athletics (283 medals, including 85 gold) for the most medals for India with 80, including 16 gold?
- QUESTION 7**
Who is set to become the first Indian sportsperson to feature at seven straight Asian Games?



Visual Question: Name this swimmer who won India's first-ever gold medal at the inaugural Games. THE HINDU ARCHIVES

- Questions and Answers to the previous day's daily quiz:** 1. Thaci was convicted by the Kosovo Specialist Chambers of The Hague. What is the mandate? **Ans: Its hearing trials of crimes committed by members of the Kosovo Liberation Army during the 1998-99 war**
2. Which sitting PM currently has an arrest warrant against him issued by the International Criminal Court in 2024? **Ans: Benjamin Netanyahu, Prime Minister of Israel**
3. This British supermodel once testified in a trial against this former Liberian president at the Special Court for Sierra Leone in The Hague. **Ans: Naomi Campbell; Charles Taylor**
4. In 2023, the ICC issued an arrest warrant against Russian President Vladimir Putin for war crimes in Ukraine. It also issued a warrant for another Russian official. Name the individual. **Ans: Maria Alekseyevna Lvova-Belova**
5. In 2016, this leader was convicted by the ICC to 18 years' imprisonment for war crimes and crimes against humanity committed in the Central African Republic. However, the leader was ultimately acquitted by the court after an appeal. Name the leader and his current position. **Ans: Jean-Pierre Bemba Gombo; Deputy PM of Transportation and Channels of Communication of the Democratic Republic of Congo**
- Visual: This leader became the first ex-head of state to stand trial before an international court since World War II. **Ans: Slobodan Milosevic**
- Early Birds:** K.N. Viswanathan | Tamal Biswas | Sunil Madhavan | Piyali Tuli | Arun Kumar Singh

From Page One

U.S. passes Bill targeting Russian energy sector

The issue had been discussed with various U.S. interlocutors at high levels, the Ministry statement said, adding that the government made it clear to the U.S. that the sanctions would have implications for the bilateral relationship and energy markets.

The Trump administration had announced an additional 25% tariff, on top of an existing 25% tariff on India in July 2025, for the purchase of Russian oil. The share of Russian crude oil in Indian oil imports fell to its lowest level in two years in December 2025, but energy markets have been under additional pressure owing to the U.S.-Iran conflict and New Delhi's import of Russian oil hit an 11-month high in April this year. However, the U.S. Treasury paused sanctions for oil shipments that were in transit before March 11, 2026, as supplies were hit following the start of the conflict in West Asia on February 28.

"To China and India: You better clean up your act. Buy your oil and gas somewhere else," said Senator Richard Blumenthal, a Connecticut Democrat, shortly after the Bill was passed.

Potential target countries

Countries that would be potential targets for the tariff are the top five "largest importers, by total volume" of Russian-origin crude oil or natural gas in the 12 months preceding the date of enactment of the law, and have knowingly made new purchases of Russian crude oil on or after 30 days from the date the Bill becomes law.

A country that is among the top five countries "facilitating Russian oil sanctions evasion" would also be eligible for the tariffs of up to 100%.

Countries that have taken significant steps to reduce their Russian natural gas imports or whose gas imports were less than 15% of Russia's total gas export, would be exempt from the sanctions.

A House amendment proposed by Democrat Steny Hoyer that sought to name the top 10 importers – China, India, Turkiye, Azerbaijan, Hungary, Slovakia, the UAE and the Kyrgyz Republic – had not passed into the final version considered on Wednesday.

Sweeping powers

The Bill, named after Senator Lindsey Graham , a prominent supporter of Ukraine, who died suddenly on July 11 this year, had passed the Senate 86-11 on August 7. Several prominent Democrats, like Elizabeth Warren and those caucusing with Democrats like Bernie Sanders, as well as some Republicans, such as Rand Paul, had opposed the Bill, concerned over the sweeping powers it would give the President or the cost it would impose, via tariffs, on Americans.

Declared dead, workers come back to get ration

This damning indictment, found in the draft information system audit report on 'Implementation of PARESHRAM and Nirman Shramik Portal in the State', is expected to be part of the Comptroller and Auditor General's Audit report for the financial year 2024-2025.

"This implies the beneficiary was alive and authenticating her Aadhaar physically to avail ration indicating fraudulent disbursement of death benefit. Further, it also indicates that medical officers issued death certificates against alive persons," the draft report says.

Subu R., the Principal Accountant General (Audit-1) of Odisha, had sent the draft report to Chithra Arumugam, then Additional Chief Secretary to the Labour and ESI Department, soliciting her response on the massive anomalies indicating corruption in the implementation of the Nirman Shramik scheme. A copy of the draft report has been obtained by *The Hindu*.

Construction workers welfare scheme

Under the Nirman Shramik scheme, building and construction workers between ages of 18 and 60 years who have completed at least 90 days of work in the preceding 12 months and are not enrolled in any other welfare fund are eligible for registration under the Building and Other Construction Workers (Regulation of Employment and Conditions of Service) Act, 1996. Once registered, workers are entitled to various welfare benefits including educational scholarships for their children, assistance for marriage, maternity, and funeral expenses, and death compensation.

A nominee is entitled to ₹2 lakh as a death benefit and ₹5,000 as funeral assistance upon the death of an eligible registered worker. All financial assistance is paid from the dedicated fund of the Building and Other Construction Workers' Welfare Board, which collects a cess of 1% of the construction cost incurred by an employer. The board had accumulated more than ₹4,000 crore by 2024.

Analysis across databases

On cross analysis of the NFSA data, audit observed that 3,013 death beneficiaries under Nirman Shramik scheme were also beneficiaries under NFSA. In 914 cases, discrepancy was also observed in the name of worker under Nirman Shramik with that of person registered under NFSA having same Aadhaar. Hence, disbursal of death benefits to those persons having difference in name updated in Aadhaar was abnormal," the audit points out.

Auditors have also analysed the database and cross verified this information with the Odisha Birth Death Registration System data provided by the Odisha Computer Application Centre.

PM pitches India as a global destination for chipmaking

The country's success in the critical industry would strengthen supply chain of entire world, says Modi; 1 lakh technicians to be trained over five years for employment in factories, adds IT Minister

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi pitched India as a "new and trustworthy location" for electronics manufacturing, urging global chipmakers to consider the country's potential to relieve electronics from the "weaponisation" of supply chains.

"This is not a sector where you set up a factory and the job is done," said Mr. Modi, who inaugurated Semicon India 2026. "Wherever semiconductor ecosystems have been built in the world, the entire ecosystem has come together only after decades of hard work. But India, with your cooperation, has worked simultaneously on chip design, manufacturing, equipment manufacturing, the materials ecosystem, testing capability, and has demonstrated success."

The Prime Minister's address came days after the India Semiconductor Mission's (ISM) second phase, which has an outlay of ₹1.27 lakh crore, was notified.

Describing India as the



High potential: Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw at SEMICON India in New Delhi on Thursday. ANI

"mother of democracy", he said, "When such a country succeeds in a critical industry, it strengthens the supply chain of the entire world. And today, when supply chains are being weaponised, its importance becomes much greater. We should also look at this development taking place in India from this larger perspective."

Semicon India 2026 brought together semiconductor and electronics firms from India and other countries. Speaking at the event, IT Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw said the govern-

ment plans to train one lakh people who will be a "global pool of talent" and can "straightaway be employed in the factories which are coming up in India".

Mr. Vaishnaw said the government would target at least 200 start-ups and firms in ISM 2.0's chip design pillar, almost double of what was done for the first phase.

The Minister added that the government was committed to training more than one lakh technicians over the coming five years for different electronics

manufacturing duties.

Global industry body SEMI's CEO Ajit Manocha estimated that the semiconductor industry would cross \$1.3 trillion this year, and \$2 trillion by 2030.

Leaders from the semiconductor industry expressed hope in India's trajectory and its role in their global plans. Applied Materials committed to invest \$5 billion over the coming five years to expand its R&D centre and supply chain.

"Earlier this year, we began commercial production at Sanand," Micron CEO Sanjay Mehrotra said. "Our current production capacity already exceeds the memory required for India's entire laptop market ... The India Semiconductor Mission, and now ISM 2.0, gave this industry a foundation it did not have before."

Infineon CEO Jochen Hanebeck called India a "market of tremendous importance", praising the "pace of progress across the Indian ecosystem". Pointing to his firm increasing hiring in India by 28%, he said that there was great potential for India in the sector.

Noel Tata opposes bid for Chandrasekaran's return

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

Noel Tata, chairman of Tata Trusts, which holds a 66% stake in Tata Sons, on Thursday voted against the reappointment of N. Chandrasekaran as chairman of Tata Sons.

Meanwhile, four Board members – Venu Srinivasan, Harish Manwani, Saurobh Agarwal and Anita M. George – approved the reappointment.

The Board also resolved to initiate steps to comply with RBI guidelines and decided to seek guidance from the RBI, Tata Trusts and other stakeholders on applicable compliance requirements.

On Saturday, the RBI rejected Tata Sons' application to de-register its Core Investment Company NBFC licence and directed it to immediately comply with listing regulations.

Tata Sons said the Board had received from Tata Trusts its unanimous resolution, dated July 28, 2025, expressing its appreciation of Mr. Chandrasekaran "for his stewardship of the Group from 2017 onwards".

"In recognition of these efforts, the Tata Trusts resolved that he be re-appointed as Executive Chairman for a further term of five years upon the expiry of his current term. Subsequently, in September 2025, the Board of Tata Sons agreed in principle to re-appoint Mr. Chandrasekaran as Executive Chairman for a further term of five years," it said in a statement.

"Pursuant to applicable provisions of law, the Board decided to obtain the relevant formal approval in February 2026. But in the absence of unanimity, the resolution was deferred for decision. In subsequent Board meetings in May 2026 and June 2026, this matter was discussed but was not resolved," the company said.

In view of the above, on August 12, Mr. Chandrasekaran, in a letter, had opted



Noel Tata

not to offer himself for re-appointment. On September 3, the Nomination and Remuneration Committee (NRC) of the Board, comprising Mr. Srinivasan, Mr. Manwani and Ms. George, met to discuss the re-appointment.

"After due deliberation and in recognition of his contributions and the larger interests of the Tata Group, the NRC unanimously resolved to request him to reconsider his decision and to recommend him for re-appointment at the next Board meeting," the statement said.

'Duly accepted'

As Mr. Chandrasekaran decided to revisit his decision not to seek re-appointment, the Tata Trusts reiterated its position that the decision has been "duly accepted and has attained finality".

"On 12 August 2026, Mr. Chandrasekaran communicated to the Tata Sons Board, his own decision not to offer himself for reappointment – a decision that was freely taken, clearly expressed and not the outcome of any process of review. It was made public without prior intimation or any deliberations with the shareholders of the company. Once such a decision has been publicly communicated, it has consequences which cannot be afterwards undone, since the Group's employees, its lenders and counterparties, the market and the majority shareholder have all proceeded on it," Tata Trusts said.

Tata Trusts said it formally placed on record its acceptance of the decision

the following day and advised Tata Sons to initiate the process for setting up a selection committee for appointing a successor, in accordance with the Articles of Association of Tata Sons.

"The Trusts' position remains unchanged, as a considered judgement of a majority shareholder. This position was reiterated in today's board meeting by the Chairman, Tata Trusts. The resolution seeking to reappoint Mr. Chandrasekaran in the Board meeting today, with four Directors voting in favour, and Mr. Noel Tata against, was a legal nullity in view of the provisions of the Articles of Association of Tata Sons," it said.

At the Board meeting, Mr. Tata submitted a legal opinion obtained from Justice D.Y. Chandrachud, former Chief Justice of India, regarding the correctness of the Trusts' stand. "The same was not taken note of by the Board," Tata Trusts said.

On the Board's decision to follow the RBI's order, Tata Trusts has asked Tata Sons to explore options other than listing and save the 'Tata model'.

At the Board meeting, Mr. Tata, said, "Tata Group was conceived as a national service carried on through business and has conducted itself so in this manner for over a century. The structure of its ownership is what has allowed it to remain so and has permitted Tata Sons to act repeatedly in ways that a purely commercial calculus would not have supported."

Mr. Tata proposed providing liquidity to the SP Group, which holds little more than 18% stake in Tata Sons and had been asking for listing. The proposal was received from the Shapoorji Pallonji (SP Group) regarding monetisation of a portion of their Tata Sons shareholding held by Sterling Investments Corporation Private Limited and Cyrus Investments Private Limited.

The Hindu Bureau
JAMMU

Two Pakistani Jaish-e-Mohammed terrorists were killed and a suspect was detained in an anti-terror operation in Jammu division's Udhampur district on Thursday.

The Jammu & Kashmir Police identified the two dead terrorists as Saddam and Mustafa. "An AK assault rifle (with four magazines), M4 carbine (with three magazines), a Glock pistol (with two magazines), and four grenades have been recovered from them," said the police.

The Army launched 'Operation Sohan' during the intervening night of September 16 and 17 following "confirmed inputs indicat-

Plea flagging issues in Delhi SIR to get 'precedence' in SC

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Thursday agreed to give "precedence" in hearing to a writ petition raising discrepancies in the conduct of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of the electoral roll in Delhi, including the removal of lakhs of voters from the draft roll for nebulous reasons.

"We will list it on Monday. Such matters will have precedence," Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant said.

The CJI was reacting to an oral mentioning by advocates Prashant Bhushan and Neha Rathi of a petition filed by activists Anjali Bhardwaj and Amrita Johri.

The plea flagged that apart from the more than 47 lakh names that have been removed as per the draft roll, the Election Commission (EC) was preparing notices to 33 lakh people on two grounds: logical discrepancies and mapping.

"Out of 97,53,577 electors who are listed on the draft Delhi SIR roll after the enumeration phase, 33,12,919 electors (33.96%) are being issued notices af-

The petition said the EC has not defined 'logical discrepancies' or laid guidelines to categorise them

ter being identified for either having no mapping (13,79,785) or for logical discrepancies (19,33,134). However, the Election Commission and the Chief Electoral Officer, Delhi) have failed to publish the list of electors to whom notices have been issued along with the specific basis thereof, contrary to the procedure," the petition said.

The petition said the term 'logical discrepancies' has neither been defined by the EC nor has any specific criteria to determine the circumstances in which an elector would fall within that category.

In the West Bengal SIR, 'logical discrepancies' could include anything from improbable family age gaps and changing parent names to entries backed by only Aadhaar. 'Mapping' meant the exercise of verifying voters' details with earlier records or their families' generational voting data.

Two Jaish terrorists killed, suspect held in Udhampur



Security officials arrest a suspect for his alleged association with two Jaish-e-Mohammad terrorists in Udhampur on Thursday. ANI

ing the presence of terrorists in Udhampur".

"Despite hostile weather, difficult terrain and poor visibility, troops of the Army's White Knight Corps, J&K Police and CRPF launched a targeted counter-terrorism operation, resulting in the neutralisation of two terro-

rists," said the Army. The arrested suspect is being questioned.

"The operation is still in progress, with search and surveillance operations continuing in the area. Security forces remain deployed to track and neutralise any remaining threat," the Army said.

Court issues arrest warrant against LeT commander

Peerzada Ashiq
SRINAGAR

A special court of the National Investigation Agency (NIA) in Jammu has issued a non-bailable arrest warrant against Pakistan-based Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT) commander Saifullah, linked to several major attacks in Jammu and Kashmir, including the 2025 Pahalgam attack.

"Keeping in view the fact that the accused person is at large and the investigating agency has not been able to procure his attendance in the ordinary manner. As such a general warrant of arrest (non-bailable) is issued against Saifullah," reads the order.

The NIA has mentioned the name of Saifullah in the case as one "operating from Pakistan and providing weapons, funds and directions to terrorists in the Kashmir Valley". The agency said it had busted a LeT module earlier in the year.

Kuki-Zo Council warns of full-fledged agitation if demands are not met

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

The Kuki-Zo Council (KZC) has threatened to launch a "full-fledged agitation" if the Centre fails to address its administrative, humanitarian, and security concerns by October 10, 2026. The organisation accused the National Investigation Agency (NIA) of selective operations against the community.

The KZC said the Kuki-Zo people were facing sev-

ere shortages of food and essential commodities in Kamjong, Kangpokpi, Non-ey, and Tamenglong districts due to an economic blockade imposed by the United Naga Council.

The Council said innocent civilians were frequently summoned by NIA for questioning, but "fewer operations appear to be conducted in Naga and Meitei areas".

It demanded the re-imposition of President's Rule in Manipur.



APPEAL

Baby Shivaay Jagga, Fortis Memorial Research Institute UHID No.13933353, 1 year is a known case of Thalassemia major. He has a Potential Matched Unrelated Donor & requires stem cell Transplant as Curative Therapy. The Estimated cost of the Transplant is Approximately Rs.32,00,000/-.

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Centre must make stance clear on U.S. law: Congress

After projecting BRICS summit's joint declaration as a sign of world's trust in India, govt. is facing bullying from a strategic partner, says party; it asks PM to ensure energy security is not sacrificed

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress on Thursday demanded that the Narendra Modi government make its position clear on the latest move in the U.S. to impose steep tariffs on countries buying Russian oil, with the party's general secretary (organisation) K.C. Venugopal asking whether India's foreign policy and energy security would be "controlled from Washington".

His remarks came after the U.S. House of Representatives passed the Lindsey O. Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act, 2026, by a vote of 262-159, clearing the way for U.S. President Donald Trump to impose tariffs of up to 100% on countries that continue to purchase Russian oil and gas. The legislation now awaits Mr. Trump's sign.

"Will the PM find the guts to stand up to the U.S.' latest Senate resolution? Will India's foreign policy



and energy sovereignty be controlled from Washington?" Mr. Venugopal said on X.

The government has been projecting the recently concluded BRICS summit's joint declaration as a symbol of the world's trust in India, but was now facing "aggressive bullying from a strategic partner", the Congress leader added.

'Affront to sovereignty'

"Given the compromised PM's track record, we are likely to see the Centre toe the U.S.' line and surrender to Washington. We demand that the Modi government clarify its stance

on this at the earliest, and ensure India's energy security is not sacrificed," Mr. Venugopal said.

His colleague and party general secretary Randeep Surjewala described the U.S.'s move as an "affront to Indian sovereignty" and questioned whether the government would "speak for the nation".

Mr. Surjewala cited remarks by Democratic Senator Richard Blumenthal after the House voted that India and China should "buy their oil and gas somewhere else".

The government had repeatedly compromised India's interests in dealing

with the U.S., the Congress leader alleged, and questioned why New Delhi should not be free to decide from whom it buys crude oil.

"Our foreign policy and sovereignty cannot be bartered at the altar of our friendship with the United States. National interests cannot be mortgaged at the altar of event management by a weak-kneed BJP govt.," Mr. Surjewala said on X.

Congress general secretary in charge of communications Jairam Ramesh simply said: "Appeasement has never paid and will never pay."

The Congress's attack came as the government sought to reassure the country that it would protect its economic and energy interests. India is monitoring developments following the passage of the legislation and remained "firmly committed" to ensuring energy security for its 1.4 billion people, the External Affairs Ministry said.

Govt. says introduction of MDR will help Indian UPI apps, denies foreign push

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

The introduction of the Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) will help more domestic payments companies to operate under UPI, contrary to the allegation that the charge has been introduced under external pressure, the government said on Thursday.

The public sector National Payments Council of India (NPCI) on Wednesday announced the MDR structure on UPI payments prompting criticism from the Opposition and allegations that U.S. pressure had pushed the Indian government to introduce this charge.

"Contrary to misleading claims made that MDR has been introduced under external pressure, introduction of MDR on select high-value transactions will enable more domestic companies to operate under UPI," the Department of Financial Services (DFS) said on X.

"Thus, the introduction is a step in protecting India's sovereignty in the



The National Payments Council announced MDR structure on UPI payments on Wednesday.

electronic payment ecosystem."

The DFS further said the allegations of U.S. pressure refer to a report by the U.S. Trade Representative (USTR) in which it cites the inability of American electronic payment services suppliers to participate in the UPI ecosystem, including credit transactions on UPI, on a level playing field with RuPay. It said that the actions by the NPCI do not rectify these American concerns.

'Only RuPay'

"The NPCI circular of 15.9.2026 does not allow credit transactions of UPI by any other credit card other than RuPay credit card," the department clarified.

ified. "There is a clear policy of only allowing RuPay credit card on UPI to enable RuPay credit card to become the preferred choice of credit card amongst users in India."

The USTR report also raised the issue of an NPCI rule mandating a maximum market share of 30% for third-party apps as a potential hindrance.

Here too, the department said that while the rule was put in place, enforcement was not possible due to market conditions.

A previous analysis by *The Hindu* shows that India's UPI market is dominated by American companies, with Walmart-owned PhonePe holding a market share of about 46% and Google Pay with 32% in the total volume of UPI transactions conducted in the country.

"Introduction of MDR on select high-value transactions will provide a self-sustaining revenue model to smaller companies to compete for higher share in the UPI ecosystem," the DFS said.

Cong. rejects claim that its MPs backed MDR move

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress on Thursday accused the Modi government of trying to use the proceedings of a Parliamentary Standing Committee to defend its decision to impose a Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) on high-value UPI transactions, saying the specific proposal had neither been placed before nor endorsed by the panel.

The Opposition party's response came after the government sought to cite the Finance Committee's earlier deliberations on the MDR, and the presence of Congress MPs when its report was adopted, to counter the political backlash over the new UPI charges.

Discussions on the broad principle of MDR could not be construed as approval of the measure announced by the government, the Congress said.

"These are pathetic attempts by the Modi Govt to divert attention from the gigantic backlash generated after the UPI tax decision taken to appease US companies & Donaldbhai," Congress general secretary Jairam Ramesh said on X.

The Finance Committee had not discussed the UPI proposal, Congress's deputy leader in the Lok Sabha Gaurav Gogoi said.

Questions had been raised about the need for it, but government representatives had not provided satisfactory answers at the time, the Congress leader added.

Mr. Gogoi reiterated the Congress's demand for withdrawal of the policy, saying it would hurt small merchants, vendors, and entrepreneurs while benefiting U.S. corporations.

EC bars rival factions from using Trinamool name and symbol for Assembly bypolls

Sreeparna Chakrabarty
NEW DELHI

The Election Commission (EC) in an interim order on Thursday barred both factions of the Trinamool Congress from using the party symbol and name in the coming Assembly bypolls in Nandigram and Rajinagar in West Bengal.

The poll body asked both factions led by former West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee and Ritabrata Banerjee, who is currently the Leader of the Opposition in the Assembly, to submit alternative names and symbols for their groups for the byelection

EC has asked both factions to submit alternative names, symbols for bypolls by 11 a.m. on Friday

tions by 11 a.m. on Friday.

The Congress termed the move a "bullet through the heart of Indian democracy".

"The EC has once again proven that it is nothing more than a puppet in the hands of the BJP – a tool to destroy democracy bit by bit..." Congress general secretary K.C. Venugopal said in a post on X. He said "freezing the AITC symbol

– after a blatantly unconstitutional hijack by the BJP – is a bullet through the heart of Indian democracy. We condemn this move, and demand that the EC immediately restore the two leaves symbol to Mamata Banerjeeji".

The EC order came after the rival factions met the poll body on Thursday for a hearing, the second in less than five days.

Thursday's hearing came on the day when scrutiny of nominations for the bypolls, scheduled for October 6, ended. Both the factions have fielded candidates on 'joda ghas phool' symbol of the Trinamool.

Wishes, messages pour in for Modi as the PM celebrates 76th birthday

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Birthday wishes and congratulatory messages poured in for Prime Minister Narendra Modi from across the political spectrum on Thursday.

President Droupadi Murmu and Vice-President C.P. Radhakrishnan conveyed their wishes, crediting Mr. Modi as a leader for driving governance reforms, inclusive growth, and progress towards a "Viksit Bharat" by 2047.

Marking the occasion, the BJP organised events such as lighting of diyas (oil lamps) and blood donation camps across the country. "Over the past 25 years, during your tenure



Well-wishers light diyas during Sankalp Abhiyan campaign, marking Narendra Modi's birthday, at Kartavya Path. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

as Chief Minister and Prime Minister, you have established many new benchmarks of good governance..." said Ms. Murmu on X.

The Vice-President said: "Under your steadfast and visionary leadership, Bharat is shining as a bright

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu, Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah, Kerala Chief Minister V. D. Satheesan, Jharkhand Chief Minister Hemant Soren were among those who sent greetings to Mr. Modi.

Home Minister Amit Shah flagged off the Seva Yatra being undertaken on 250 motorcycles from Vadnagar in Gujarat to Uttar Pradesh's Varanasi, where it will conclude on October 17.

The event is part of the 'Seva Sankalp Abhiyan', a month-long programme till October 17, marking Mr. Modi's birthday and 25 years since he became Gujarat Chief Minister.

SC seeks report on 25 unnatural deaths in Manipur camps

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Thursday ordered the Manipur Chief Secretary to submit a detailed report on 25 unnatural deaths, including an alleged sexual assault, reported among internally displaced persons in relief camps across the State.

Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant found that the Manipur government had not given satisfactory responses about the deaths to the Supreme Court-appointed Justice Gita Mittal Committee, which is monitoring the relief and rehabilitation provided to the victims of the ethnic violence in 2023. "This is very, very shocking. One of them involves sexual assault. The information sought by the committee was very serious," CJI Kant addressed the State's Advocate-General and Additional Solicitor-General Aishwarya Bhati, who also is also representing the Manipur government.

The court ordered that

Report must include steps taken for the safety and dignity of internally-displaced persons, orders SC

the Chief Secretary's report must be comprehensive and include post-mortem details. The Bench said the report must also contain measures taken to ensure the safety and dignity of internally-displaced persons. The State counsel said the delay may have been due to the appointment of a new Chief Secretary a few days ago.

The order also referred to a report highlighting that 640 deaths occurred in relief camps across eight districts while post-mortem examinations were allegedly conducted in only 20 cases. The court sought explanations over this and why only ₹20,000 to ₹30,000 was given as compensation in these cases. It also asked State Legal Services Authority to register FIRs in all cases of unnatural deaths.

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SALE OF STANDARD PADDY SEEDS DURING 2026-27

INVITATION FOR BID No.Mktg-62/2026

OSSC Ltd invites e-Tender from agencies for Sale of standard paddy seeds available at Baragada, Baleshwar, Bhabanipatana, Bhubaneswar, Boudh, Brahmapur, Cuttack and Jayapur Zones of OSSC Ltd, as per the details attached with the tender schedule on item wise rate contract basis during 2026-27.

Name of the work	Sale of standard paddy seeds out of Kharif-2025 produce
No. of Work	One
Availability of bid document in the portal	15.00 hours on dt.11.09.2026 to 17.00 hours on dt.29.09.2026
Last date of receipt of tender in the portal	17.00 hours on dt.29.09.2026
Date and time of Opening of Bid	10.30 hours on dt.30.09.2026

Sd/-

Managing Director, OSSC Ltd., BBSR

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No.KKRTC/CO/COSP/07/2026-27 Dated:17.09.2026

TENDER INVITING NOTICE (THROUGH KPP PORTAL MODE ONLY)

Tenders through KPP portal (pre-qualification & commercial) are invited for supply of following items.

Sl. No.	Tender No.	Tender Nomenclature	Estimate Value (Rs.)	Last date for submission of tender
01	KKRTC/2026-27/IND0206/Call-2	Supply & Installation of Desktop Computers, Laptops, Laser Printers, Dot Matrix Printers and Tabs	3.14 Crore	30.09.2026 at 15.00 hrs
02	KKRTC/2025-26/IND0189/Call-3	Procurement of Plywood Sheets	0.58 Crore	30.09.2026 at 15.00 hrs
03	KKRTC/2026-27/IND0218/Call-2	Procurement of ERW GI Tubes and CR ERW MS Tubes	0.70 Crore	30.09.2026 at 15.00 hrs
04	KKRTC/2025-26/IND0159/Call-6	Supply and Installation of Minor Garage Equipments	0.30 Crore	30.09.2026 at 15.00 hrs
05	KKRTC/2026-27/IND0224/Call-3	Procurement of Automotive Bulbs	0.39 Crore	30.09.2026 at 15.00 hrs

All the details of Tender, Registration, Tender form documents etc. are available at <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in/>. Mail to cospnekrtc@gmail.com or support@eprocelpdesk.com for further information if required. Further, any addendum /corrigendum related to changes in terms and conditions of tender, specification and calendar of events etc. will be uploaded only through KPP portal.

Sd/-

Controller of Stores and Purchases

(Tender Inviting Authority)

DIPR/Kalaburagi/550/KSMC&A/2026-27

GOVERNMENT OF INDIA – DEPARTMENT OF SPACE CONSTRUCTION & MAINTENANCE GROUP, SDSC – SHAR SRIHARIKOTA – 524124

Brief E-TENDER NOTICE

e-Tender Notice No.CMG/C/CON/268720 Date: 15/09/2026

On behalf of President of India, EPC tenders are invited through e-tendering for the following work:

Brief Name of work	Est. Value (Rs)
Package - 3 Construction of Road Top Coat (DBM & BC) in EPC Mode-III at SLC, Tuticorin.	612 Lakhs

Last date for sale (Tender documents can be downloaded) up to 01/10/2026, 14:30 hrs. For eligibility criteria and other details, interested tenderers may please refer to the detailed bilingual (Hindi-English) Notice Inviting Tenders (NIT) on the website <https://www.isro.gov.in/Tenders.html> and tender free view at <https://www.tenderwizard.com/isro>

Sd/-

GROUP HEAD, CMG/ SDSC SHAR

ODISHA POWER TRANSMISSION CORPORATION LIMITED
(A Government of Odisha Undertaking)
Regd. Office: OPTCL Tech Tower, Janpath, Saheed Nagar, Bhubaneswar-751007

NOTICE INVITING E-TENDER

E-Tender No.	Tender Description:	Estimated Cost
CPC-70/2026-27	Bids are invited from reputed manufactures under single stage two part bidding system for Engineering, Supply, Erection, Testing & Commissioning of twin High Temperature Low Sag (HTLS) Conductor after dismantling of twin AAAC Moose Conductor in existing 400 KV Meramundali-Mendhasal DC Line along with up-gradation of equipment and Bus at respective Grid Sub-station on EPC/ Turnkey Contract Basis. Last Date & Time of Submission of Bid: 09.10.2026 upto 12:45 P.M.	Rs. 301,22,38,089/-
CZ-e-TCN-12/2026-27	Bids are invited from reputed Bidders having valid PAN, GST registration certificate, valid Electrical license(EHT/HT), Civil license and having experience for Supply and Laying of Geo synthetic Fabric and Remetaling work at 220KV Switchyard of GSS,Bidanasi, in e-tendering mode only. Last Date & Time of Submission of Bid: 08.10.2026 upto 14:30 Hrs.	Rs. 71,35,927/-

Complete set of bidding documents are available at www.tenderwizard.com/OPTCL and www.optcl.co.in.

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HIPR-57/2026-27

INBRIEF



TVS expects single-digit growth for 2-wheeler industry

TVS Motor Company, which on Thursday rolled out festive enhancements across its premium motorcycle portfolio of Apache and Ronin, said it remains “cautiously optimistic” about demand in the upcoming festive season. The company expects the two-wheeler industry to post single-digit growth this festive season on account of a high base created by pre-buying ahead of last year’s GST rate cut, even as it highlighted strong momentum in the premium motorcycle segment. “We are looking at a single-digit festive growth [for the industry] because last year, due to GST, there was already a huge impact as people were holding back purchases for a long time before the festive season started,” TVS Motor Company Head Business, Premium, Vimal Sumbly told PTI. Building on this momentum ahead of the festive season, TVS on Thursday unveiled 18 new motorcycles with enhancements across its premium range, including the Apache RTR 160, Apache RTR 160 4V, Apache RTR 200 4V and RR 310, along with the Ronin.

Govt. puts 25 coal blocks on sale in 16th round of auctions

The Coal Ministry Thursday formally inaugurated that sixteenth round of commercial mine auctions putting forth 25 blocks, comprising 21 fully explored and four partially explored mines. The mines are spread across nine-coal bearing states including Arunachal Pradesh, Bihar, Chhattisgarh, Jharkhand, Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra, Odisha, Telangana and West Bengal. The latest round forms part of the government’s larger commercial coal mining framework that has had 147 mines auctioned till date, which are expected to cumulatively bring forth revenues of over ₹47,500 crore and entails projected capital investment of more than ₹55,000 crore across nine coal-bearing states.

51% of India’s July oil imports from Russia

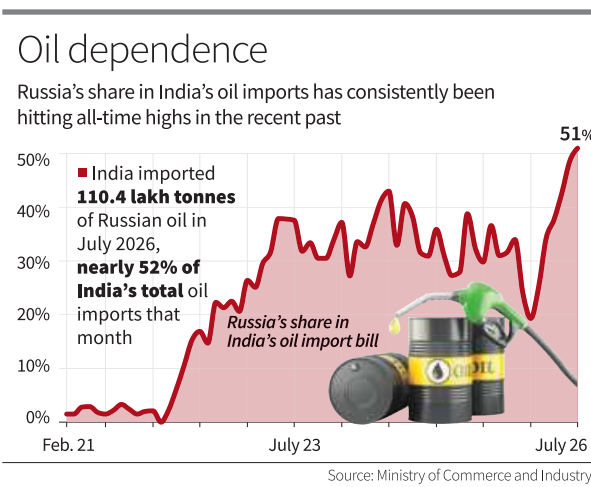
Bill passed by U.S. House of Representatives seeks to impose tariffs of up to 100% on top 5 countries absorbing the largest shares of Russia’s oil

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

Russia accounted for more than 51% of India’s oil imports in July, an all-time-high, up from just a little less than 50% in the previous month, the latest official data shows. This comes even as the U.S. House of Representatives on Wednesday passed a Bill that could see 100% tariffs being imposed on India and a few other countries for their import of Russian oil.

The U.S. House of Representatives passed the ‘Lindsey O. Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act of 2026’ on September 16. The Act seeks to impose tariffs of up to 100% on the top 5 countries absorbing the largest shares of Russia’s oil exports.

An analysis of data from the Ministry of Commerce and Industry shows that India imported 110.4 lakh tonnes of oil from Russia in July 2026, the latest month for which data is available. This works out to nearly 52% of India’s total oil im-



ports that month, the highest-ever share that Russian oil has enjoyed.

India’s oil imports from Russia in July 2026 were also 26% higher than in June, and nearly 55% higher than in July last year.

This sharp increase in volumes, coupled with elevated oil prices, also meant that India’s Russian oil import bill shot up in July 2026 as compared to last year. That is, India’s import bill on Russian oil stood at \$7.3 billion in July 2026 more than double the \$3.6 billion spent in July last year. The U.S. legislation

that threatens the tariffs for such imports will now head to the desk of U.S. President Donald Trump. It is expected to become law soon after, since Mr. Trump has been keen to strangle Russia’s oil exports in a bid to cut off financing for the country’s war with Ukraine.

The data, however, shows that India received Russian oil at a slight discount. While India paid an average of \$669 a tonne for its total oil imports in July 2026, it paid Russia an average of \$658.6 a tonne for its oil that month.

Semicon 2.0 locks in chip assets sale

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Approved chip plants under the Semicon 2.0 programme will not be allowed to sell or mortgage

any part of the project till the declaration of commercial production of the entire project, as per guidelines issued on Thursday.

Units receiving fiscal support under the scheme

shall have to remain in commercial production for a period of at least (three) years from the date of commencement of commercial production and provide an undertaking to the same.

‘Oil India to spend ₹15,000 crore on deepwater exploration over 3 years’

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI

Oil India Ltd. (OIL) has outlined ₹15,000 crore capital expenditure for exploration in deepwater and ultra deepwater areas over the next three years, Ranjit Rath, CMD, told reporters.

“In terms of preparedness, we have already created a capex of ₹15,000 crore [for deepwater and ultra deepwater exploration],” stated Mr. Rath.

Numaligarh refinery

The OIL chief also said he expected the 9 million tonne per annum (MTPA) expansion work at Numaligarh refinery to be com-



Ranjit Rath

pleted by the end of FY27 with stabilisation likely taking 9-12 months more.

On overseas activities, Mr. Rath said OIL would focus on exploration and producing assets though primary interest tilted towards the latter.

The capital expenditure will further boost the Maharatna explorer-producer’s offshore exploration footprint across the Andaman, Kerala-Konkan, Krishna-Godavari and Mahanadi basins.

Oil India had already undertaken seismic studies, and the interpretation of the findings would help identify potential drilling locations, said the company’s chief.

Responding to a query from *The Hindu*, Mr. Rath said the company does not anticipate any major challenges in accessing the infrastructure or technology required for offshore exploration and production.

Mr. Rath informed that the state-owned explorer-producer had relinquished assets in Bangladesh and Gabon as part of broader consolidation strategy.

Prospective areas

Speaking to *The Hindu*, he explained, “As part of our overseas assets, we will continue to look at more prospective areas - both producing and exploration assets but the primary interest will be in producing assets which will give us an early or an immediate monetisation opportunity.”

The CMD added exploration would continue to be OIL’s mainstay on the domestic front.

India’s August crude imports dropped 3%, spend rose 18%: data

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI

India’s imports of crude oil in August slid 3% though the import bill stood about 18.2% higher over same month last year, as per provisional government data, indicating prolonged West Asia tension uncertainty.

August also saw import volumes of and spending on liquefied natural gas (LNG) staying almost unchanged year-on-year. India’s crude oil basket averaged \$90.19/barrel in August versus \$82.04/barrel in July and \$69.11/barrel in August last year.

India’s net import bill – the difference between imports of petroleum pro-

ducts, crude and gas imports and exports of petroleum products – was flat at \$9.3 billion.

India’s refiners imported 19 million metric tonne (MMT) of crude in August for almost \$11.7 billion against \$9.9 billion to import 19.6 MMT of crude oil same month last year.

The unchanged net import bill can be attributed to India’s refiners earning about 43% more money from exports despite a more than 14% decline in quantities supplied during the reported period.

August LNG imports grew 0.1% to 2.915 million standard cubic meter for which India spent some \$1.2 billion.

PSU general insurers log ₹10,051-crore loss, pvt. insurers in green

Balasubramanyam C.P.
CHENNAI

The four public sector general insurers swung to a combined net loss of ₹10,050.79 crore in 2025-26 from a net profit of ₹802.87 crore in the previous year, reversing the improvement seen over the preceding two years, as per latest data from General Insurance Council.

The deterioration was accompanied by a sharp widening of underwriting losses. Combined, the four insurers’ underwriting loss rose to ₹30,892.09 crore in FY26 from ₹18,366.41 crore in FY25. The combined ratio increased to 134.37% from 121.23%.

A combined ratio above

100% means claims and operating expenses exceed premium.

Solvency ratio measures an insurer’s capital cushion against its regulatory capital requirement, while the combined ratio measures underwriting performance by comparing claims and operating expenses with premiums.

The PSU insurers reported a combined net loss of ₹6,740.01 crore in FY22 and ₹10,592.64 crore in FY23 before logging a profit of ₹100.37 crore in FY24 and ₹802.87 crore in FY25.

Private general insurers however, were profitable in FY26. They clocked combined underwriting loss of ₹13,657.92 crore and ₹8,580.29 crore net profit.

कार्यालय अतिरिक्त मुख्य अभियन्ता, सा.नि.वि., संभाग द्वितीय उदयपुर नु. बौसवाड़ा
क्रमांक : सी-462
दिनांक : 11.09.2026
अल्पकालिन निविदा सूचना संख्या - 09 / 2026-27
NIB Code :- PWD2627A2683
सड़क निर्माण कार्य हेतु इच्छुक संवेदको से ऑनलाईन माध्यम से दिनांक 12.09.2026 से दिनांक 22.09.2026, सायं 06:00 बजे तक निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है। निविदा का अन्य विवरण वेबसाइट (http://www.eproc.rajasthan.gov.in) और http://www.sppp.rajasthan.gov.in) पर देखा जा सकता है। उपापन की कुल अनुमानित लागत राशि रु. Rs. 1087.01 लाख है।
UBN- PWD2627WLOB11908
DIPR/C/15983/2026

THE KERALA STATE BEVERAGES (MANUFACTURING & MARKETING) CORPORATION LTD
(A GOVERNMENT OF KERALA UNDERTAKING)
BEVCO TOWER, PALAYAM, VIKAS BHAVAN PO., TRIVANDRUM-695 033, Phone: 0471 2790100
E-TENDER ADVERTISEMENT
Ref: No.: KSBC/4142/2024-SECS 18.09.2026
E-tenders in a two-cover system are invited on behalf of the Kerala State Beverages Corporation (KSBC) from eligible, experienced bidders for the following work: For more details visit www.etenders.kerala.gov.in
e-Tender ID Location Bid submission End date
2026_KSBC_869564_1 Supply of eco-friendly Cloth Carry Bags to FL-09 Warehouses of BEVCO across Kerala 29-Sep-2026 05:00 PM
Sd/-
Chairperson & Managing Director

AHMEDABAD MUNICIPAL CORPORATION
LIGHT DEPARTMENT - TENDER NOTICE
AMC invites sealed competitive bids from interested Bidders for the below mentioned work:
1 IMPLEMENTATION OF 75 MW (AC) GRID-CONNECTED GROUND-MOUNTED SOLAR PV POWER PROJECT ALONG WITH 7.5 MW / 30 MWh BATTERY ENERGY STORAGE SYSTEM (BESS) UNDER GROUP CAPTIVE MODE FOR AHMEDABAD MUNICIPAL CORPORATION (AMC) IN THE STATE OF GUJARAT.
Online Submission up to Date : 09/10/2026 Only up to 04:00 PM.
Last Date of Submission of (Hardcopy) Date : 14/10/2026 up to 04:00 PM.
Tender details available on <https://tender.nprocure.com>

BANGALORE ELECTRICITY SUPPLY COMPANY LIMITED
(Wholly Owned Government of Karnataka Undertaking)
BRIEF TENDER NOTIFICATION
(Through KPP Portal Only)
BESCOM invites tenders vide inquiry No: BESCOM/2026-27/SE0498 through KPP Portal from eligible bidders for “Implementation of Common Billing Solution across all ESCOMs of Karnataka”. Bid documents Available from: 21.09.2026, 04:00 PM Onwards.
The Tenders can be obtained through KPP portal website <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in> Aspiring Bidders need to register on KPP portal. Further Bidders can take assistance with KPPP help desk contact numbers (080-46010000, 080-68948777) or email at support@eprocelpdesk.com.
Sd/-
General Manager (ICT & MIS.), BESCOM, 5th Floor, Belaku Bhavana, K.R. Circle, Bengaluru-560 001.

Dr. NTR UNIVERSITY OF HEALTH SCIENCES :: A.P :: VIJAYAWADA-3
No. 23/We/TS/AE/26
TENDER NOTICE
Sealed Tenders are invited for the following work at Dr. NTR University of Health Sciences, Vijayawada.
SI No. Name of the work
1. Peripheral Scanning and onscreen evaluation of Answer Booklets i.e., Computer Based Evaluation and up-loading the data for Dr. NTR UHS, Vijayawada
Note: For further details visit www.approcurement.gov.in
Sd/- Dr. T. Sai Sudheer, REGISTRAR

Kerala State IT Mission
Department of Electronics & IT,
Government of Kerala.
Website: <http://www.itmission.kerala.gov.in/>
TENDER NOTICE
1. Tender for the Supply, Installation and Commissioning of Storage Solution at Kerala State Data Centres.
Tender ID : 2026_KSITM_869351_1
Tender Reference No. DDFS/nSDC/648/2014-KSITM
2. Tender for the Supply, Installation and Commissioning of servers at Kerala State Data Centres.
Tender ID : 2026_KSITM_869968_1
Tender Reference No. SDC/19/2016-KSITM
Detailed Notification and RFP documents can be downloaded from <https://etenders.kerala.gov.in/>
D3/542/2026/I&PRD

CENTRAL ELECTRICITY REGULATORY COMMISSION
6th, 7th, & 8th Floor, Tower-B, World Trade Centre, Nauroji Nagar, New Delhi-110029
Petition No. 129/TD/2026 Dated: 14.9.2026
NOTICE UNDER CLAUSE (a) OF SUB-SECTION (5) OF SECTION 15 OF THE ELECTRICITY ACT, 2003 (the Act)
An application for the grant of a Category-V licence for inter-State trading in electricity in all States and Union Territories of India has been made before the Commission by **SKay Infratech Private Limited**, F-437, 4th Floor Artha Mart Techzone-IV, Noida Ext., Gautam Budha Nagar-201306, U.P.
2. A copy of the application, along with its annexures and enclosures, made by the applicant for the grant of an inter-State trading licence to **SKay Infratech Private Limited** before the Commission can be accessed at the website www.neplindia.co.in or inspected by any person in the Commission's office by following the laid down procedure.
3. On consideration of the material available on record, the Commission is satisfied that prima facie the applicant qualifies for the grant of a licence for inter-State trading in electricity and by order dated 14.9.2026, the Commission has proposed to grant a Category-V licence to the applicant for inter-State trading in electricity in all States and Union Territories of India.
4. Notice is hereby given in pursuance of clause (a) of sub-section (5) of Section 15 of the Act to invite suggestions or objections, if any, to the proposal to grant the licence for inter-State trading in electricity as aforesaid by the Commission to be received by the undersigned latest by **3.10.2026** at the above noted address. The objections or suggestions received after the specified date shall not be considered.
5. The Commission has fixed the application for final disposal on **6.10.2026** and the person who files the suggestions or objections may in his discretion attend the hearing, for which no TA/DA shall be paid by the Commission.
Sd/-
(Harpreet Singh Pruthi)
Secretary

BLITZKRIEG

Abhishek smashes fastest ton in a T20I featuring Test-playing nations



SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

Abhishek Sharma scored the fastest hundred in a T20I featuring Test-playing nations. His 30-ball century against Afghanistan in New Delhi on Thursday bettered Kiwi Finn Allen's effort (33b) versus South Africa earlier this year. Estonia's Sahil Chauhan (27b) holds the record for the fastest T20I ton. It was against Cyprus in 2024.

MAKING MERRY

Abhishek breaks record for highest percentage of runs in boundaries



SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

Abhishek Sharma broke the record for the highest percentage of runs scored in boundaries in a T20I hundred. The India opener scored 94.44% of his runs in fours and sixes (102/108) against the Afghans. It bettered Turkiye's Muhammad Fahad's 93.33% (112/120) against Bulgaria in Sofia last year.

DOMINANT SHOW

Vlaeminck and Mills claim three each as Australia-A blanks India-A



FILE PHOTO

Tayla Vlaeminck, *in pic.*, and Lilly Mills scalped three apiece as Australia-A beat India-A by seven runs at New Chandigarh on Thursday to sweep the three-match T20 series. **The scores:** Australia-A 168/5 in 20 overs (Webb 52, Learoyd 61) bt India-A 161 in 19.5 overs (Vrinda 69, Tejal 42, Vlaeminck 3/24, Mills 3/40).

CLOSE CALL

Pakistan survives Thailand scare to reach Asian Games semifinals



PCB

Pakistan survived a scare against Thailand to seal a semifinal spot in the Asian Games women's cricket competition while Bangladesh advanced on the basis of its higher ranking after its match against China was abandoned due to a wet outfield. **The scores:** Thailand 91/4 in 11 overs lost to Pakistan 92/7 in 10.4 overs. **Toss:** Pakistan.

Abhishek's hurricane hundred powers Men in Blue's emphatic series sweep

The left-hander's record-breaking 34-ball 108 and fellow-opener Samson's fifty take India to 221 for seven; the Afghans get bundled out for 94

CRICKET

Vivek Krishnan
NEW DELHI

Six-hitting is a skill that Abhishek Sharma has honed to perfection. He can make it appear ridiculously easy, as though he is playing around with a joystick in a video game, but make no mistake: few can do what the 26-year-old does time and again in the T20 version. A sublime example came in the third T20I against Afghanistan at the Arun Jaitley Stadium on Thursday as Abhishek hammered a record-breaking 34-ball 108, studded with nine fours and 11 sixes, to take India to 221 for seven.

With Afghanistan capitulating for 94 in response, Shreyas Iyer & Co. completed a resounding 127-run win for a 3-0 sweep. Nitish Kumar struck thrice in an over while Ravi Bishnoi also provided three breakthroughs.

Abhishek's century took merely 30 balls, the fastest against a Test-playing nation and the third-quickest in all in this format. Sanju Samson chipped in with 50 off 35 balls, forging a sensational opening stand of 142 in 9.5 overs. The surface appeared to be a shirtfront when Abhishek and Samson were on song, but the others didn't find it as easy.



Breathtaking: Abhishek hit nine fours and 11 maxims in his dazzling knock. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

Abhishek imposed himself straightaway. In the second over, Azmatullah Omarzai felt the pinch. The first of the opener's maxims came when he swi-

velled and pulled effortlessly beyond deep square-leg. Omarzai persisted with the shorter length and paid the price. Off the fourth ball, he

pulled out a forehand slap past mid-on for four. Two deliveries later, he made room and slashed a back-of-a-length delivery over cover for another six.

SCOREBOARD

INDIA

Sanju Samson c Rashid b Omarzai 50 (35b, 2x4, 4x6), Abhishek Sharma c Gurbaz b Rashid 108 (34b, 9x4, 11x6), Tilak Varma run out 2 (5b), Shreyas Iyer run out 29 (20b, 2x6), Shivam Dube c Rashid b Omarzai 14 (10b, 1x4, 1x6), Ishan Kishan run out 10 (8b, 1x4), Nitish Kumar c Mujeeb b Ahmadzai 1 (4b), Axar Patel (not out) 5 (4b), Ravi Bishnoi (not out) 0 (0b); Extras (w-2): 2; Total (for seven wkts. in 20 overs): 221.

FALL OF WICKETS
1-142 (Abhishek, 9.5 overs), 2-152 (Tilak, 11.1), 3-164 (Samson, 13.1), 4-186 (Dube, 15.3), 5-205 (Kishan, 17.5), 6-206 (Nitish, 18.3), 7-218 (Shreyas, 19.4).

AFGHANISTAN BOWLING
Farooqi 4-0-39-0, Omarzai 3-0-27-2, Mujeeb 4-0-45-0, Nabi 1-0-29-0, Rashid 4-0-43-1, Ahmadzai 4-0-38-1.

AFGHANISTAN
Rahmanullah Gurbaz b Axar 15 (11b, 3x4), Ibrahim Zadran c Kishan b Yash Thakur 25 (16b,

4x4, 1x6), Sediqullah Atal c Abhishek b Axar 1 (3b), Darwish Rasooli b Bumrah 0 (1b), Azmatullah Omarzai c Bishnoi b Nitish 17 (13b, 1x4, 1x6), Noor ul Rahman c Nitish b Bishnoi 11 (15b, 2x4), Mohammad Nabi b Nitish 8 (9b, 1x4), Rashid Khan b Bishnoi 6 (5b, 1x4), Mujeeb Ur Rahman b Nitish 0 (2b), Abdollah Ahmadzai c Axar b Bishnoi 6 (8b, 1x4), Fazalhaq Farooqi (not out) 0 (2b); Extras (lb-1, w-4): 5; Total (in 14.1 overs): 94.

FALL OF WICKETS
1-31 (Gurbaz, 3.1), 2-33 (Sediqullah, 3.6), 3-39 (Rasooli, 4.5), 4-47 (Ibrahim, 5.2), 5-70 (Noor, 8.5), 6-81 (Nabi, 11.1), 7-82 (Omarzai, 11.3), 8-82 (Mujeeb, 11.5), 9-89 (Rashid, 12.5).

INDIA BOWLING
Nitish 4-0-25-3, Bumrah 2-0-16-1, Yash Thakur 2-0-17-1, Axar 3-0-9-2, Bishnoi 3.1-0-26-3. **Toss:** Afghanistan. **PoM and PoS:** Abhishek. India won by 127 runs to clinch series 3-0.

Having quickly sized up the Afghan attack, the southpaw's carnage found a higher gear. The next over, bowled by Fazalhaq Farooqi, went for 23 runs as the Punjab lad stitched together a sequence that read 6, 6, 4, 4.

Afghanistan turned to spin early in the hope of disturbing India's rhythm. Instead, Samson, who had scored three off his first seven balls, joined the six-hitting party. In the fourth over, he deposited Mujeeb Ur Rahman over long-on.

What followed was a 29-

run over by off-spinner Mohammad Nabi as the openers took turns to flex their firepower. By the time leggie Rashid Khan conceded 15 runs in the final over of the PowerPlay, India had raced to 100 for none.

In the ninth over, Abhishek entered the record books by reaching the three-figure mark. Ironically, his celebration was unlike the action that had transpired till then: he took off his helmet, sat down and soaked in the moment with a meditative pose.



Contrasting fortunes: Gukesh was held while Nihal won. FIDE

Nihal saves the day for India; women cruise

CHESS OLYMPIAD

Sports Bureau

Nihal Sarin saved the blushes for India on day two of the Chess Olympiad at Samarkand. His win on the second board was the reason why India, the defending champion, could beat a much lower-rated Indonesia 2.5-1.5 in the Open section on Thursday. Nihal, though, was in considerable trouble in his game against Arif Abdul Hafiz before he won in 37 moves. R. Praggnanandhaa, the in-form player who was making his first appearance in this edition, World champion D. Gukesh and Vidit Gujrathi were all held to draws.

Praggnanandhaa did try his best to stretch his opponent Susanto Megaranto, who, however, played solidly to ensure that the rook-pawn endgame was indeed drawn, after 79 moves.

The Indian women, also the reigning champions, were more convincing than the men, just as they were in the opening round.

They beat Finland 3.5-0.5. There were wins for Divya Deshmukh, Vantika Agrawal and B. Savitha Shri, but on the top board, R. Vaishali had to settle for a draw with Anastasia Keinanen in 88 moves. So the top-seeded Indian women could not quite score the full points, which they had against Dominican Republic.

The results (second round):
Open: India bt Indonesia 2.5-1.5 (R. Praggnanandhaa drew with Susanto Megaranto; Nihal Sarin bt Arif Abdul Hafiz; D. Gukesh drew with Satriya Cahaya; Vidit Gujrathi drew with Nayaka Budhidharma)
Uzbekistan bt Peru 3.5-0.5; USA bt Mongolia 2.5-1.5; China bt Chile 3-1; Germany bt Uzbekistan-3 3.5-0.5; Azerbaijan bt The Philippines 3-1.
Women: India bt Finland 3.5-0.5 (R. Vaishali drew with Anastasia Keinanen; Divya Deshmukh bt Johanna Paasikangas; Vantika Agrawal bt Sara-Olivia Sippola; B. Savitha Shri bt Heja Lehtinen).
Uzbekistan bt Ecuador 4-0; Kazakhstan bt Bosnia & Herzegovina 3-1; USA bt Belgium 4-0; Georgia drew with Montenegro 2-2; Ukraine bt Lithuania 4-0; Netherlands bt Luxembourg 4-0; China bt Colombia 3.5-0.5; Azerbaijan bt Denmark 4-0.

For Japan's cricket team, the occasion means more

ASIAN GAMES

Jonathan Selvaraj
NAGOYA

India's women's cricket team, ranked No. 3 in T20Is, opens its Asian Games campaign against 39th-ranked Japan on Friday at Korogi Sports Park in Nisshin, Aichi.

On paper it looks lopsided: India fields full-time professionals, while Japan's squad juggles jobs and studies around international cricket. Japan hadn't even qualified for the 2022 Hangzhou Games.

For captain Mai Yanagida, the occasion means more than the opponent. "It is incredibly exciting. I have waited a decade to play in the Asian Games," she tells *Sportstar*.

Japan's men debuted in Hangzhou, beating Cambodia and briefly making national news. "The Asian Games is like the Olympics. It's one of those things that people really do kind of get



All in: The Japanese team at a practice session recently. JCA

behind," says Alan Curr, COO of Japan Cricket Association.

The women now get a chance to showcase the sport at home. "I hope this will be an opportunity to raise awareness of cricket and inspire people to dream of aiming for the Japanese national team in the future," says 39-year-old pacer Kurumi Ota.

Only 14 women's cricket clubs exist nationwide and Ota, a systems engineer, stepped away from cricket for seven years, returning only after a major project launched.

Still, she carries something rare: an Asian Games medal, bronze from

Guangzhou in 2010, cricket's Games debut. "Winning the bronze medal together with my teammates is my fondest memory," she says.

The change since is striking – from practising under overpasses to today's international-standard grounds. Both players are eager to face India's stars, Yanagida watching Shafali Verma and Smriti Mandhana, Ota targeting Harmanpreet Kaur.

"A lot of Japanese people still do not know their country has a cricket team," Yanagida says. "Although awareness is growing, most people are still genuinely surprised".

Chaos and crisis: Japan in an alternate universe?

Uthra Ganesan
NAGOYA

For years, Japan was the epitome of perfection, the country that planned things down to the last possible detail. The Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games, starting on Saturday, threatens to dent that reputation.

It began with concerns, whispered initially before growing loud enough and from quarters widespread enough, about the city and the organisers' preparedness for an event whose magnitude is larger than the Olympics. It became immediate when delegates from various National Olympic associations expressed reservations in private about the conditions and facilities for athletes and officials.

None of it caused alarm, given Japan's reputation of pulling off mega events without a glitch. The Tokyo Olympics, in the immediate aftermath of Covid, had received appreciation for managing a never-before situation. The 2026 Asiad, however, has been far from it.

The first lot of Indian



Not the ideal start: The organisers have come under the scanner for accommodation issues. AFP

athletes, including rowers who landed in the city, struggled to get accommodation, waiting without any arrangements for almost 12 hours.

The officials fared no better. A quick ask around made it clear that it was becoming the norm, with athletes from several countries suffering similar fate. The accommodation – on cruise ship Costa Serena and modified shipping containers in keeping with the organisers' insistence on sustainability – has also come in for criticism, both

for poor quality and insufficient quantity.

Videos of the containers have been shocking to say the least, resembling detention centres than athlete residences. South Korea's Byun Jun-hyung, member of the basketball team, took to social media to show a leaking sink and wet floor, pleading "Please help me." An image of Indian shot putter Tajinderpal Singh Toor showed him in his allotted container with the space and beds clearly too small for him.

There have been logisti-

cal issues as well, with Korea and Qatar football teams being bussed to the baseball stadium on Tuesday. The Chinese badminton team had to rely on local Chinese to travel from the airport. Many Indian athletes, who did finally manage to get places to stay, were welcomed with closed shutters and a notice on Thursday morning saying breakfast was not included in their bookings.

"The organisers have washed their hands of everything and said that there is no accommodation and

that we need to manage things ourselves. We have got our rowers and other athletes booked into different hotels. There is hardly any support or facility at the airport.

"I am staying in a small container but imagine the plight of athletes who are taller and muscular. We have been raising the issues every day at the CDM meetings and will do it again tomorrow (Friday)," Indian contingent's Chef de Mission (CDM) Sahdev Yadav said.

"There have been cases where coaches, team officials, and athletes have been assigned the same room. It creates challenging situations such as men and women being assigned together," Japan's deputy Chef de Mission Hisashi Mizutori told a news conference on Thursday.

The positive remains the volunteers but they are few and far between that they are practically non-existent. The city has nothing to indicate an event of this magnitude is happening. Japan might still pull it off. But the claims of perfection have been undone.



GETTY IMAGES

Cold blood, hot streak

An Achilles injury, just four days of practice, and a final against the top seed and two-time defending champion... Rybakina's path to the US Open title was anything but simple. However, her tennis made it look that way. In the process, she ascended to the top of the world rankings

Anirudh Velamuri

Sport has an old rule about momentum: catch fire late in a season, and the off-season usually douses it. That sentiment holds for most part. But, as with most things in life, there are exceptions. Elena Rybakina's is one.

The Russian-born Kazakh couldn't get past the fourth round at the Grand Slams last year. Form looked to have deserted her and the season was all set to be chalked up as yet another 'learning experience' in her career.

Then, it all changed. She came through a tough set of tournaments in September and October, won in Ningbo and closed the year by defeating Aryna Sabalenka in the WTA Finals title decider, taking home more than \$five million in prize money, the largest purse in women's tennis history at that time.

The soft-spoken 27-year-old later disappeared for the off-season. When she resumed action, she picked up from where she had left off, looking just as dangerous as she'd been. Rybakina reached the Australian Open final without dropping a set, clawed back from 0-3 down in the third set to beat Sabalenka again for her second Major. She became

the first player in eight years to win the WTA Finals and the Australian Open in succession.

What followed was, by any measure, a strong season: a title in Stuttgart along with runner-up finishes at Indian Wells and the Canadian Open. She also banked her 400th career win on the way.

The underlying numbers are absurd. Since last year's US Open, nobody on the Tour has won more matches than Rybakina (62) and nobody has beaten more

top-10 players (16, with a 16-6 record). She leads the field in winners (1,569), in aces (394) and break points saved (65.5%). She made six finals (tied with Jessica Pegula for most on the Tour) and clinched four crowns, more than anyone else.

Put it all together and you get a first-time World No. 1: the first from Kazakhstan, and at 27 years and 89 days, the second-oldest woman ever to reach the summit for the first time. She rose to the top, tournament by tournament, so relentlessly that by the time it actually happened, nobody blinked.

And yet a year ago, the idea of Rybakina dethroning Sabalenka looked unthinkable, unattainable even. Last September, she had 3,833 points to Sabalenka's 11,225 – barely a third. By last month, that gap had shrunk to 360 points, before she finally ended Sabalenka's 99-week reign as the No. 1. Even before she ascended to the top of

the rankings, Rybakina had already beaten a reigning World No. 1 nine times, a mark bettered only by Gabriela Sabatini's 10. The Kazakh has now beaten nine of the last 10 women who have held the top ranking. Only Ashleigh Barty got away.

Crowning moment

Impressive as all that is, the true crowning moment of Rybakina's year came at Flushing Meadows; she barely stumbled, let alone look anywhere near beatable. The strange part is that heading into the tournament, nobody was asking how far she'd go. They were instead wondering if she'd play at all.

On August 14, she was steam-rolled by Iga Swiatek to the Canadian Open title. A week later, Rybakina was forced to retire after just five games of her Cincinnati quarterfinal against the same opponent.

An Achilles injury was suspected, though little else was confirmed. In the week before the US Open, Rybakina barely picked up a racquet. As far as preparation for one of the biggest titles in the sport goes, it was far from ideal.

"It wasn't the best time, for sure, because I was so upset. I didn't know how it was going to be, day by day. We arrived in New York, did an MRI and it didn't look that great. We had to talk with a lot of doctors to get an opinion on what we should do," she said, hours after conquering New York.

She started practising just four days before the US Open got underway and with each match, she looked less like a woman shaking off rust and more like one reminding everyone who she was. The power was there and the aces were pulled out of nowhere when they were needed the most.

"Just four days of practice, a lot of belief in myself and talking with the team non-stop about the tactics... that's how I played in Canada, how I played in Cincinnati. I mean, it's just so many things. Everything went my way. I'm shocked."

Her tennis over the fortnight told a different story. Nothing about this triumph was shocking. Everything came together for Rybakina one way or the other.

Sabalenka loves to feast on her opponent's second serves, as Pegula was harshly reminded in the semifinals. So when Rybakina landed just eight of her 30 first serves in the opening set of the final, logic dictated that the Belarusian would seize control of the contest.

The logic was wrong. Rybakina pulled out heavier, quicker second serves and deep, powerful groundstrokes to put Sabalenka on the back foot. If one moment captured how the final unfolded, it was the last game of the opening set, where Rybakina couldn't hit a first serve but ended up on top despite everything thrown at her.

By the end of the night, as she did at

the WTA Finals, Rybakina had a trophy and a fat cheque in hand, but this time as World No. 1. Four years ago, she barely managed a smile after conquering Wimbledon, and the tennis world wondered if she'd ever let herself feel a title the way champions are supposed to. In New York, something shifted. The fists were raised, the celebration stayed brief; however, underneath it, for the first time, was an unmistakable and hard-earned joy.

Rybakina wins the way glaciers move: silently, relentlessly, until you look up one day and the entire landscape has changed. New York didn't just hand her a trophy; it handed women's tennis a warning wrapped in ice – quiet on the outside, catastrophic on the inside.

A year earlier, after finishing runner-up to Rybakina at the WTA Finals, Sabalenka – far from being tennis' most gracious loser – was overheard reaching for a Russian idiom that translated to: "Once a year, even a stick shoots," suggesting Rybakina's form was little more than a fluke. Famous last words.

Overcoming controversy

Like most of the sport's best players, Rybakina hasn't always made headlines for the right reasons. First came the injuries and health scares that dragged her out of tournaments through 2024 and '25. Then her 'worrying' relationship with coach Stefano Vukov landed under the microscope.

In September 2024, she fired Vukov and hired Novak Djokovic's former coach Goran Ivanisevic, before reinstating Vukov. A WTA investigation later found that Vukov had engaged in abusive conduct towards Rybakina, and he was banned from coaching at WTA events in January 2025. The ban was overturned on appeal that August.

Rybakina never softened her stance towards the WTA through it all, even declining to pose for a photo with the then-CEO Portia Archer after beating Sabalenka to win the WTA Finals on November 8.

Long before the WTA formally looked into the Vukov relationship, fans and pundits had already suspected that something was off. He was always very vocal in relentlessly criticising during matches, well beyond any reasonable idea of 'tough love' coaching.

One can argue that Vukov has been noticeably softer since the ban ended. Criticism has largely given way to encouragement. Optimists will call it a man who learnt his lesson. Cynics will call it a man who learnt to behave when the cameras were rolling.

Rybakina herself has stayed quiet on the specifics, but she's hinted that having her team back in place has mattered.

"I think I have a very good team and good people around me now. It definitely helps. A lot was going on in the previous

year outside of the court. I think now all my focus is on tennis. I can't always perform at my best. There are always ups and downs, but I think we've been doing a very good job, taking the right decisions in certain situations, because every day is a challenge," she said last week.

The Vukov chapter may never be fully closed in public, but it changes nothing about where Rybakina stands right now. What once looked like a hot streak has long since stopped resembling one. Nothing about her has come out as a fluke.

She will now head into tournaments, starting with the China Open later this month, as the top seed and a clear title favourite. Given how balanced she is in success and adversity, none of that seems likely to rattle her.

"I feel like you will appreciate and think about it [becoming World No. 1] even more when you finish your career. For now, you need to keep going. You never know how long you're going to stay. All my thoughts are just for the next match," she said after her quarterfinal win over Qinwen Zheng.

Call it humility. Call it how elite athletes are wired. Call it a deliberate way of shrugging off the spotlight before it gets too heavy. Whatever it is, one thing isn't up for debate: the girl who once played tennis as an after-school pastime, who didn't consider it a career until she was 17, has walked out of New York as the most dominant force in women's tennis. Rybakina is pure potential energy, coiled at the very peak of her arc. Buckle up.

THE GIST

Since the 2025 US Open, nobody on the Tour has won more matches than Rybakina (62) and nobody has beaten more top-10 players (16, with a 16-6 record) than her

In the same period, the Kazakh made six finals (tied with Pegula for most on the Tour) and won four titles, more than anyone else

An Achilles issue nearly kept her out of this season's US Open. She recovered in time to go all the way, beating Sabalenka in the final

Last year, Rybakina couldn't go past the fourth round at the Slams. This season, she has won two Majors and also become the new World No. 1

By September 2025, she had 3,833 points to Sabalenka's 11,225 – barely a third. In the space of 12 months, Rybakina has overturned that deficit and ended the latter's 99-week reign at the top of the rankings

The ace is Rybakina's most potent weapon and she served the most aces (116) in a Slam in New York this year. In fact, she served an ace on championship point at both the Australian Open and US Open



HEALTH

Why patient safety needs more than hospital checklists

Patient safety begins even before treatment: it encompasses the right diagnosis, accurate, timely care, safe hospital environments, protected data and an understanding from all stakeholders to put the patient first, say doctors; the WHO's theme for World Patient Safety Day 2026 is 'safe care for non-communicable diseases'

Siddharth Kumar Singh

A patient enters an operating theatre for a procedure on the right knee. The limb is marked, the scans are available and the surgical team has checked the records. Just before the operation begins, the team stops. A nurse reads out the patient's identity, the procedure planned, the side of the body to be operated on and the type of anaesthesia. The surgeon, anaesthetist and other members of the team confirm the details. This brief pause, known as 'timeout', may take only a few minutes. But it is one of several layers of checks designed to prevent a potentially devastating mistake.

This exercise was an example of what Syed Mohammed Ghouse, consultant robotic and transplant surgeon, Asian Institute of Nephrology and Urology, described as the 'Swiss cheese mechanism', in which several layers of checks are put in place so that if one safety barrier fails, another can detect the error before it reaches the patient.

The need for such multiple safeguards was at the heart of World Patient Safety Day, observed on September 17. The World Health Organization's theme for 2026 was 'Safe care for non-communicable diseases'.

Doctors say patient safety has to be viewed much more broadly than preventing an obvious surgical or medication error. Ranga Reddy Burri, president, Infection Control Academy of India, said the understanding of patient safety has now expanded considerably: the responsibility cannot rest only with doctors and nurses. Policymakers, accreditation agencies, patients, caregivers, families, communities and even housekeeping staff have roles to play. "A hospital just having an accreditation doesn't actually guarantee the kind of safety that is required," Dr. Burri said, stressing the need to train all stakeholders involved in a patient's journey.

Patient safety begins even before treatment starts, noted Dr. Burri. The availability of sophisticated diagnostic equipment has not necessarily solved the problem of ensuring an accurate diagnosis. "The diagnosis quality has actually gone down over a period of time," he said. He attributed part of the problem to doctors moving away from basic clinical examination, including auscultation, percussion, palpation and physical examination. He described the emerging situation as 'no touch' healthcare, where doctors can sometimes begin looking at a computer even before adequately engaging with the patient.

Neurologist Sudhir Kumar of Apollo



Safety first: Hospital staff conducted a mock drill on mass casualty management earlier this year at the Government General Hospital in Ongole. Experts say all stakeholders should have training in patient safety. KOMMURI SRINIVAS

Hospitals, Hyderabad, also pointed to the importance of ensuring quality of medical education as the number of medical colleges and seats increases. "If we don't ensure quality services, then it will worsen the patient's safety because diagnosis may be missed; treatment may not be perfect," he said.

Medication problems

Medication safety remains another major area of concern. Dr. Kumar said spurious and fake medicines continue to pose a patient-safety risk despite the existence of drug inspectors and regulatory checks.

Dr. Ghouse pointed to another problem of look-alike and sound-alike medicines. With a large number of pharmaceutical companies and medicines available, drugs with similar names can create opportunities for errors, particularly when medicines are handled by someone who is distracted or not sufficiently alert.

He said hospitals use measures such as separate labelling and storing look-alike and sound-alike medicines away from each other, along with other quality-control measures.

Technology has reduced some types of prescription errors, but doctors say it has not eliminated them. Dr. Ghouse said typed and printed prescriptions are still not universal, especially at small clinics. Dr. Kumar said prescription errors can also occur when different doctors prescribe medicines under different

brand names or when medicines from the same group are inadvertently duplicated. "For example, a patient may end up taking the same medicine twice because different brand names make it difficult to recognise that the drugs are essentially the same."

Within hospitals

Some patient-safety risks are less dramatic but can still have serious consequences, particularly among older patients. Dr. Burri said falls in hospitals, including falls while patients are going to the bathroom or getting out of bed, can result in major injuries. "Hospitals need to ensure that their physical environments are designed to prevent slipping and other hazards."

Patient safety also extends beyond just their wards or rooms. Dr. Kumar pointed to hospital fires, electrical problems and other infrastructure-related hazards as areas that require greater attention. He said while the number of hospitals was increasing, some facilities are decades old, raising questions about who regularly audits their wiring and electrical connections.

For Dr. Burri, infection prevention and antimicrobial resistance (AMR) remain central to the patient-safety conversation. Unnecessary antibiotic administration, delayed diagnosis, unhygienic environments and non-adherence to infection-prevention and control guidelines can all contribute to the

problem, he said.

These risks can become particularly important for patients with chronic diseases, who may require repeated interactions with healthcare facilities. Dr. Burri said patients with conditions such as chronic kidney disease, lung diseases and cancer may have vulnerabilities that make infection prevention an important component of safe care. "Healthcare workers and administrators therefore have a central role in ensuring that infection-control practices are followed," he added.

Data and AI

As healthcare becomes increasingly digital, patient safety is also becoming connected to data privacy. Dr. Kumar said medical information is private, but increasing digitisation has created new risks around cybersecurity and access to medical records.

Artificial intelligence is increasingly entering healthcare, but Dr. Kumar said it should remain a tool rather than become a substitute for clinical reasoning.

For all the technology, protocols and checklists being introduced in hospitals, the doctors point to one element that cannot be removed from the equation, the patient. Dr. Burri said patients, families, caregivers and communities must understand their own role in ensuring safety.

(siddharth.kumar@thehindu.co.in)

THE GIST

Doctors say patient safety has to be viewed much more broadly than preventing an obvious surgical or medication error. Policymakers, accreditation agencies, patients, caregivers, families, communities and even housekeeping staff have roles to play in patient safety

Doctors also attribute part of the problem to doctors moving away from basic clinical examination, including auscultation, percussion, palpation and physical examination. They describe the emerging situation as 'no touch' healthcare, where doctors can sometimes begin looking at a computer even before adequately engaging with the patient

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HUMERUS



Melanoma in India: messaging about skin cancer needs to change, to catch it early

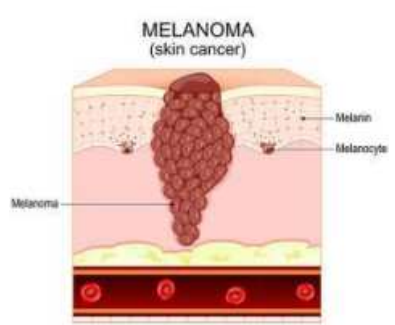
Jyoti Bajpai

Thousands of patients in India are diagnosed with melanoma, a type of skin cancer, each year.

While melanoma is far less common here than in Western populations, it is far from rare and the way it presents in our patient population makes it uniquely difficult to detect early. Too many patients come to us when the disease is already advanced, precisely at a time when treatment options have never been more powerful or more personalised. This contrast between available therapies and the stage at which patients are diagnosed defines one of the most pressing challenges in melanoma care in India today.

The warning signs most people associate with skin cancer come from research developed for fairer-skinned populations, where melanoma tends to appear on sun-exposed areas as an irregular or darkening mole. That picture does not reflect what clinicians see in India.

Melanoma here, most commonly presents on the soles of the feet or beneath the nails, sites that are rarely examined and even more rarely associated with cancer. This condition is called



Spreading awareness: Thousands of patients in India are diagnosed with melanoma, a type of skin cancer, each year. GETTY IMAGES

acral lentiginous melanoma, a subtype that accounts for 35 to 60% of cases in dark-skinned individuals. Such lesions are frequently mistaken for bruises, fungal infections, or diabetic ulcers, and by the time a biopsy is taken, the disease has often progressed.

Mucosal melanomas, a rare type of cancer that starts in the mucous membranes, are highly aggressive with a very low chance of recovery and produce few early warning signs. Most are diagnosed only after spread has occurred.

Any pigmented lesion that changes or persists, wherever it appears on the body, deserves investigation rather than reassurance.

When I began my oncology career, managing advanced melanoma meant offering patients limited and rarely durable options. That has fortunately changed significantly.

The foundational shift came from James Allison and Tasuku Honjo, whose discoveries on CTLA-4 and PD-1 earned them the 2018 Nobel Prize in Physiology or Medicine. Their research established the principle of immune-checkpoint blockade: rather than attacking a tumour directly, we can sometimes release the biological brakes that stop the patient's own immune system from doing so. The results can be extraordinary.

Precision medicine has reshaped the approach in parallel. Some melanomas carry specific mutations, particularly in the BRAF pathway, that can be directly targeted with molecularly designed therapies. This is where next-generation sequencing, or NGS, becomes critical. In simple terms, it reads the genetic blueprint of a patient's tumour and identifies the alterations that should guide treatment, turning what was once a single clinical decision into a detailed, individualised process.

The melanoma story is not over; it is only becoming more

exciting. TIL therapy takes tumour-infiltrating lymphocytes, expands them in the laboratory, and reinfuses them in far greater numbers, a step toward truly personalised cellular treatment. In August 2026, intismeran, a personalised mRNA vaccine built from the patient's own tumour sequence, was combined with pembrolizumab in high-risk melanoma patients after surgery. The results were striking: a significant reduction in recurrence compared with pembrolizumab alone, making it the first positive late-stage trial of a personalised mRNA cancer vaccine, though survival data remain pending.

What still needs to change

All of these advances deliver their best results when treatment begins early. The more sophisticated our therapies become, the more clearly we see that they work best before the disease has spread. In India, awareness and referral gaps continue to push diagnosis toward advanced stages.

(Prof. Jyoti Bajpai is director – medical precision immuno-oncology, Apollo Hospitals, Mumbai & Western Zone drjyoti_ba@apollohospitals.com)